



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 16th July, 2025

The House met at 2.41 p.m.

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the item numbered 5—Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 15th July, 2025.

Page 1...4—

Yes, Hon Member?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, page 1, “Minutes of the Thirteenth ...” Is it “...Thirteenth or Thirtieth ...”?

Alright, it is “Thirteenth”, then that is correct.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 4...17—

Yes, Prof Kingsley Nyarko?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, on page 15, I need your guidance on the item numbered 15 titled “Motion” and if you would not mind, I will combine item numbered 12 and 13. Order 105 says and with your leave I read:

“A Motion, unless moved at the Second Reading or Consideration Stage of a Bill, shall be seconded, and if not seconded shall not be debated or entered in the Votes and Proceedings.”

Mr Speaker, I have observed that the item numbered 12 and 15, which are procedural, have been moved and seconded at the Second Reading and Consideration Stage. When the Motion in the item numbered 13 was moved by the Hon Minister for Education, it was not seconded, but the Report was rather presented by the Chairman of the Committee. But, under the Motion in the item numbered 15, it was moved by the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, and seconded by the Hon Member for Cape Coast South, Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan. I want you to help me to appreciate—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Can you refer to the Rules that deals specifically with Second Reading?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, Order 105—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Rules in relation to Second Reading.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, it is found in the Order 167 (1) titled “Second Reading of Bills”. With your permission, I read:

“When the Motion is moved, *that a Bill now read or read a Second Time*, a full debate shall ensue, on the basis of the explanatory”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which Order are you reading?

Prof Nyarko: You said I should read—I read Order 105—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mention just the provision that deals with Second Reading.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, Order 167(1), (2) and (3).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you may read.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, Order 167 says:

“(1) When a Motion is moved “*that a Bill be now read a Second Time*”, a full debate shall ensue on the basis of the explanatory memorandum and the report from the relevant Committee.

(2) The debate on the Motion for the Second Reading shall also relate to the Fiscal Impact Analysis of the Bill and the effect on the economy generally.

(3) Where the Motion is carried, the Clerk shall read aloud the Long Title of the Bill, and the Bill shall be considered as read a Second Time”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Look at it clearly, there is no room for secondment. But it talks about a Report of the Committee, so that should be the relevant Order that guides the Second Reading Stage. We have Rules dealing generally with Motions, and we have a specific Rule dealing with the Second Reading, and where there are specific rules; the specific rules take primacy over the general Rules. So, when we have Order 167, dealing specifically with the Second Reading, that is the Rule that should guide the House.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I agree, but my contention with the Motion moved in the item numbered 15— During the Consideration Stage, the Motion was moved and seconded. I am of the view that that defeats Order 105; unless, when it is the procedural Motion, it can be moved and seconded.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Motion moved in the item numbered 15 is a procedural Motion.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, that is what I am asking.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is not the Motion for the Second Reading. So, when you move a Motion for a procedural motion, that procedural motion must be seconded.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, that is the clarity I wanted from you, because if you read Order 105, it does not come out clearly. That was my confusion.

2.51 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the confusion is whether or not a procedural Motion should be seconded.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, my point is that, if you take your time, Order 105 says that—It is general. It reads:

“A Motion, unless moved at the Second Reading or Consideration Stage of a Bill, shall be seconded, and if not seconded shall not be debated or entered in the Votes and Proceedings”.

My point is that because it is general, we have a procedural Motion but I have seen that all the procedural Motions were moved and seconded, but if you look at this Order, it says that it should not be and I am saying that if it is the case that procedural Motions can be seconded.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Prof Nyarko, from Order 105— let us read it together:

“A Motion, unless moved at the Second Reading or Consideration Stage of a Bill, shall be seconded, and if not seconded shall not be debated or entered in the Votes and Proceedings”.

What this means is that a Motion for Second Reading and a Motion at the

Consideration Stage are not seconded and this is in line with the relevant Order for Second Reading; that is 169. So, apart from a Motion for Second Reading and a Motion at the Consideration Stage, all other Motions, including a procedural Motion, must be seconded.

So, there is no ambiguity and confusion about the Order if you look at Order 105, together with Order 167, of the Standing Orders. So, the Motion numbered 15 is a procedural Motion and, within the meaning of the rules, not being a Motion at a Second Reading, not being a Motion at a Consideration Stage, must be seconded.

Prof Nyarko: This is clear now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 16...18—

Yes, Hon John Darko?

Mr John Darko: Mr Speaker, yesterday, during the Consideration Stage of the Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025, a quorum was raised as an issue and you ordered the Clerks-at-the-Table to ring the bell and then do the counting, but I see that it is not recorded.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That will be captured by the *Official Report*, not the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Page 19...23.

Yes, Hon Member?

Supt Rtd Peter Toobu Lanchene: Mr Speaker, page 22, the item numbered

3, the name of the Acting Chief Fire Officer was spelt with an omission of the “r”. The name is “Mrs Daniella Mawusi Ntow Sarpong”. The “Sarpong” has an “r” between the “a” and the “p”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table, take note.

Page 23—

Yes?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with the greatest respect to my senior, I think I have known her personally and the name is as it is. It is without “r”. That can be fact-checked, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

So, Hon Peter Lanchene, the indication is that she writes her “Sarpong” without an “r”.

Supt Rtd Toobu: Mr Speaker, there is no objection.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Page 24...25—

Yes, Hon John Darko?

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, with this one, I will need your guidance.

On page 25, Committee on Subsidiary Legislation, I was there, but my name is not here. I do not know whether that has

to be corrected here or from the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, if it is a mistake coming from the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation, all you need to do is to draw the attention of the Committee to it and that will subsequently be reflected upon the attention of the Table being drawn to it. Because where we are, there will be difficulty indicating whether what the Committee captures here is wrong or is right, particularly what the Committee sent to the Table.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, I can vouch for my Colleague from Suame.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am not also doubting his presence—

Mr Boamah: He was at the meeting yesterday and we will take the necessary steps for the attendance to reflect in the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Mr Frist Deputy Speaker: So, I am not doubting his presence. Sometimes, the omission may be coming from the clerk to the Committee. So, steps should be taken to do the necessary correction by the clerk to Committee checking the attendance.

Page 26?

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Vote and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 15th July 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, the next item is the item numbered 6, Questions.

Hon Members, Questions have been slated for the Minister for Roads and Highways.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with all respect, before our Colleague, the Minister, takes the appropriate chair, we were at Conclave and we had agreed on the Businesses to prosecute. But I want to bring to the notice of the Deputy Leader that we had engaged and said that, today, we should have a Committee of the Whole. I want to find out if he has made any progress on the scheduled Committee of the Whole with the Minister for Finance.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I think if I recollect correctly, I think we said that, obviously, because of the Mid-Year Budget Review, we should wait for the Minister to present that Mid-Year Budget Review before we go on to do that. That was my understanding, so, I do not know where—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, ordinarily, we should not be doing this, but the Mid-Year Budget Review, we are told is coming on Thursday, 24th July, 2025, and we had said that we want outstanding issues to be dealt with before. So, maybe, let me remind the Deputy Majority Leader that we can forgive him today.

He should reach out to the Minister, so that we can have him tomorrow. Tomorrow is Thursday. We can have the Committee of the Whole before he

comes next week. It is very important because the mood at the back of the Deputy Majority Leader is not too good.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: I believe that there were two issues. One was to get the Minister here for the Committee of the Whole and then the second was actually to get him here to answer Questions. And it is on that basis of the two issues that we said that we will wait for him to do that. But if the Minority Chief Whip still wishes that the Minister comes to the Committee of the Whole, I will talk to the Minister, but I cannot guarantee that, as I stand here, I can get that done tomorrow.

But I will definitely get in touch with him and see if that is possible. The Minister was here yesterday. He actually came to the Chamber yesterday, so he is in town. So, I will try and reach out to him and see if we can do that. But we have a Business Committee meeting tomorrow, Thursday. I will suggest that we look at it when we go to the Business Committee meeting tomorrow to see if we can get him in the ensuing days.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Speaker, I am amenable to that. But this is to just tell the Deputy Majority Leader that he should not forget.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are also a Member of the Business Committee, so in the unlikely, far-fetched and very remote event that he forgets, you can remind him.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I take a cue.

3.01p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before the Questions, let me acknowledge the presence of students from University of Cape Coast, Valco Hall Parliamentary Council. They are here to visit us and they are led by Rt Hon Zekiah Ibrahim, Speaker of the Parliamentary Council at the University of Cape Coast, Valco Hall. They are from the Cape Coast North Constituency and are 30 in number.

[Students of University of Cape Coast Valco Hall Parliamentary Council were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then we have Polling Station Executives, led by Albert Ofosu, Polling Station Secretary, and they are from the Atiwa West Constituency. They are 350 in number.

[Polling Station Executives from Atiwa West were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Again, we have the Smartest Starters Kid Academy, led by Charles Addo, Head of Department, and they are from the Effutu Constituency. They are 32 in number.

[Pupils of Smartest Starters Kid Academy were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them and wish them a fruitful visit to Parliament. Thank you for coming.

Hon Members, the first Question on the list stands in the name of Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissie, Hon Member of Parliament for Ahanta West. The Question is numbered 243.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

Status of Selected Road Projects in Ahanta West

Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissie (NDC — Ahanta West): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the status of the following road projects in the Ahanta West Consitutency which were abandoned in 2020: (i) Sankor to Cape Three Points (ii) Aboadi to Ayem (iii) Aboadi to Butre (iv) Enyano to Egyambra and (v) Ewusiejoe to Hotopo that was abandoned in 2020.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we should take note that when you are called upon to ask a Question, you must read the Question as it is captured on the Order Paper.

Yes, Hon Minister, your Answer?

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

(i) Sankor — Cape Three Points

Background

Mr Speaker, the Sankor-Cape Three Points Road (25km) is strategically located within the Ahanta West Municipality of the Western Region. The road connects the Agona Nkwanta-Dixcove road (Regional Route R84) at Sankor to the southernmost part of the country, thus Cape Three Points.

Current Programme

The road has been awarded under five different contracts under the contract titles: “Regravelling of Sankor - Cape Three Points Road (Km 0-5) LOT 1”, “Regravelling of Sankor - Cape Three Points Road (Km 5-10) LOT 2”, “Regravelling of Sankor - Cape Three Points Road (Km 10-15) LOT 3”, “Regravelling of Sankor - Cape Three Points Road (Km 15-20) LOT 3” and “Regravelling of Sankor - Cape Three Points Road (Km 20-25) LOT 4.

Regravelling of Sankor — Cape Three Points Road (Km 0-5) LOT 1

Works commenced on 24th September, 2020 for completion by 23rd June, 2021. The physical progress achieved is 1.5 per cent. The contractor is not on site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

Regravelling of Sankor — Cape Three Points Road (Km 5-10) LOT 2

Works commenced on 6th October, 2020 for completion by 5th July, 2021.

The physical progress achieved is at 19.73 per cent. The contractor is not on site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

Regravelling of Sankor — Cape Three Points Road (Km 10-15) LOT 3

Works commenced on 8th September, 2020 for completion by 7th June, 2021. The physical progress achieved is 13.77 per cent. The contractor is not on site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

Regravelling of Sankor — Cape Three Points Road (Km 15-20) LOT 3

Works commenced on 16th September, 2019 for completion by 31st December, 2022. The physical progress achieved is 92 per cent. The contractor is not on site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

Regravelling of Sankor — Cape Three Points Road (Km 20-25) LOT 4

Works commenced on 16th September, 2019 for completion by 1st October, 2020. The physical progress achieved is 76.45 per cent. The contractor is not on

site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

(ii) Aboadi — Ayiem Road

Background

The Aboadi - Ayiem Feeder Road is 13km long. The road is located in the Ahanta West District of the Western Region. It is an engineered road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Aboadi — Ayiem Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled, “Upgrading of Aboadi - Ayiem and other Feeder Roads (42.1km)”. The contract was awarded on 30th December, 2020 for completion by 29th June, 2022. The overall progress of work is estimated at 17 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

(iii) Aboadi — Butre Road

Background

The Aboadi - Butre Feeder Road is 12.2km long. The road is located in the Ahanta West District of the Western Region. It is an engineered road in fair surface condition.

Current Programme

The Aboadi — Butre Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled,

“Upgrading of Tonto - Aketechie - Aboadi Feeder Road (14.2km)”. The contract was awarded on 11th December, 2020 for completion by 2nd February, 2023. The overall progress of works is estimated at 37 per cent physical completion.

The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

(iv) Enyano — Egyambra Road

Background

The Enyano — Egyambra road is captured on the DFR Road database as Egyambra Jn. — Egyambra Feeder Road (14.9km). The road is located in the Ahanta West District of the Western Region. It is an engineered road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Egyambra Jn. — Egyambra Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled, “Upgrading of Nyamebekyere - Agyambra Feeder Road & others (16.3km)”. The contract was awarded on 30th December, 2020 for completion by 23rd August, 2023. The overall progress of works is estimated at 15 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

(v) Ewusiejoe — Hotopo Road**Background**

The Ewusiejoe - Hotopo Feeder Road is 2.5km long. The road is

located in the Ahanta West District of the Western Region. It is an engineered road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Ewusiejoe - Hotopo Feeder Road was awarded under the

contract titled, “Upgrading of Aboadi — Ayiem and other Feeder Roads (42.1km)”. The contract was awarded on 30th December, 2020 for completion by 29th June, 2022. The overall progress of work is estimated at 17 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back

to site to complete the outstanding works.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Ms Bissue: Mr Speaker, I heard the Hon Minister say that efforts are being made, so in order for me to send back good results to my people of Ahanta West, is it possible for the Hon Minister to give some timelines? I know these projects have been abandoned for years, but is there anything I can take back home, at least, to assure them that it is going to be done?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, yes, because it is a contract, there are procedures to be followed in terms of what you do when contractors are not on site. So, the first thing would be to encourage the contractors to come on site.

3.11 p.m.

If they refuse, we would write warning letters to them and if that fails, we would terminate the contract lawfully and then we repackage the project for award to another contractor when funds become available.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further question?

Ms Bissue: No question. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. This being a constituency-specific question, we will now move to the Question numbered 244, standing in the name of Hon Emmanuel Kwaku Boam, Member of Parliament (MP) for Pru East.

**Immediate and Long-Term
Interventions to Rehabilitate Ejura-
Yeji Highway**

Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (NDC — Pru East): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the immediate and long-term interventions being taken to rehabilitate and maintain the Ejura-Yeji Highway to ensure the safety of motorists and commuters.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Background

The Ejura-Atebubu-Yeji Road forms part of the Inter-Regional Route (IR04). The road is 113.4 kilometres long, (that is from Amantin to Yeji), and traverses Atebubu-Amantin Municipality, Pru West and then Pru East Districts. The road is bituminous surface dressed and in fair condition.

Current Programme

The road has been considered under the 2025/2026 routine maintenance programme.

Future Programme

Engineering studies have been carried out on the road for consideration under the 2026 budget upon availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Boam: Thank you very much. Around 2020, there was a truncation between Atebubu-Prang stretch, and that has actually diverted the road, causing a diversion of about 20 metres from the main road. I do not know if the Minister is aware that as the rains have set in, there is the likelihood that this part of the road might also suffer another damage. It might truncate movement from Atebubu

to Yeji, which then means that we have to use the Kintampo stretch to hit the Abease-Prang. If it is part of the immediate plans that we would plead that we look at it from that side, so that it will be fixed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is your question?

Mr Boam: My question is, is the Minister aware, and has there been any plans to make sure that particular bridge between Atebubu and Prang, that is the Yeji stretch, is maintained to ensure there would not be any truncation, should there be any rains?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker. As I previously said, we have scheduled this road for routine maintenance this year. However, depending on the scope of damage my Colleague is talking about, further works will be carried out when funds become available. So, Mr Speaker, the agencies will take a second look at what he has just raised, being the Member of Parliament for the area.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is also a constituency-specific question. We will move to the Question numbered 245, standing in the name of Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo, Member of Parliament for Lambussie.

Yes?

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Hon Member to ask Question 245 is not actually here, but he has given permission to the Hon Member of Parliament for Sissala East to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I give permission and he takes authority. If he does not have his authority by permission, then I will not allow him to ask the Question.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Leader should rather advert his mind to Order 88(3). The provision of Order 88 (3) is clear – it is incumbent upon the one who has been given the authority. So, he should do the needful and catch the eye of the Speaker.

Mr Mohammed Issah Bataglia: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I want to come under Order 88(3) to stand in for my Colleague, Prof—I have the authority—*[Interruption]*—Yes, that is what I am saying.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Mr Bataglia: Mr Speaker, I seek your leave under Order 88(3), to stand in for my Colleague and ask the Question on his behalf. He is out of this country on another official duty.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There is a content of Order 88(3), so I can only permit you, if you have the authority of

the questioner. So, that is what you should place on record.

Mr Bataglia: Mr Speaker, I am building my point based on my Leader—My Leader has already given the indication.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you have the authority?

Mr Bataglia: I have his authority, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You may proceed to ask the Question.

Completion of Brutu to Lambussie Road and Lambussie — Billaw—Bawman Road

Mr Mohammed Issah Bataglia on behalf of Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo (NDC — Lambussie): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise on behalf of the Member of Parliament for Lambussie to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following stalled road works in Lambussie will be completed: (i) Brutu to Lambussie road and (ii) Lambussie – Billaw – Bawman Road.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Background

The Brutu – Lambussie – Bagwong (R132) is a 21.13km regional road in the Lambussie District of the Upper West

region. (i) Brutu to Lambussie and (ii) Lambussie – Billaw – Bawman road.

Current Programme

The road has been awarded under three different contracts with the following contract titles: “Upgrading of Tumu-Han-Lawra Road (km 45 – 70) (Addendum – Dualisation of Nandom Town Roads and Upgrading of Nandom-Lambussie-Brutu), Regraveling of Lambussie-Bagwong Road (km 0.5 – 8.5) and Regraveling of Lambussie-Bagwong Road (km 8.5 – 16.4)”.

(a) Upgrading of Tumu-Han-Lawra Road (km 45 – 70) (Addendum – Dualisation of Nandom Town Roads and Upgrading of Nandom-Lambussie-Brutu)

The contract was awarded on 23rd December, 2021 and commenced on 27th June, 2022 for completion by 27th June, 2024. The physical progress achieved is 25 per cent. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

b) Regraveling of Lambussie-Bagwong Road (km 0.5 – 8.5)

The contract commenced on 24th January, 2020 for completion by 22nd June, 2023. The physical progress achieved is 83 per cent. The Contractor has suspended works due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

c) Regraveling of Lambussie-Bagwong Road (km 8.5 – 16.4)

The contract was awarded on 20th August, 2019 and works commenced on 13th September, 2019 for completion by 30th June, 2024. The physical progress achieved is 100 per cent. Works are substantially completed

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Bataglia: Mr Speaker, no.

I thank you the Minister for the Answer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also a constituency-specific question. We will move to the Question numbered 256, standing in the name of Hon Mohammed Adams Sukparu, Member of Parliament for Sissala West. You have the floor.

Status of the Gwollu to Fieimuo-Hamele Road Construction Project

Mr Mohammed Adam Sukparu (NDC — Sissala West): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the status of the Gwollu to Fieimuo-Hamele Road construction project.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

3.21 p.m.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

The Tumu-Hamile Road (R-131) is a regional road that connects Tumu in the Sissala East Municipality to Hamile in the Lambussie District.

The total length of this trunk road is 94km and passes through major towns such as Hamile, Felimon, Wiro, Gwall, Gwollu, Sorbelle and Tumu. Current Programme

The first 40km of the road from Hamile has been awarded under a contract titled “Construction of Hamile-Tumu Road (Km 0-40)”. The project commenced on the 14th October, 2016 for completion by 30th September.

Physical progress of work 60.1 per cent.

The Contractor has suspended work due to delay in payment for works done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back on site to complete the outstanding works.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Bataglia: Mr Speaker, no.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also a constituency-specific Question so we will move to Question numbered 257 also standing in

the name of Hon Mohammed Adams Sukparu.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Construction of Roads in Sissala West

Mr Mohammed Adams Sukparu (NDC — Sissala West): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the state of the road construction project from Silbelle through Jawia to Gwollu.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Tumu-Hamile Road (R-131) is a regional road that connects Tumu in the Sissala East Municipality to Hamile in the Lambussie District. The total length of the trunk road is 94 km and passes through major towns such as Hamile, Felimon, Wiro, Gwall, Gwollu, Sorbelle, and Tumu.

The Silbelle-Jawia-Gwollu road is a continuation of the Hamile-Tumu trunk road which is already under construction from Hamile.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies have been carried out on the road for consideration under the 2026 Budget upon the availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Sukparu: Yes, Mr Speaker. I want to find out from our hardworking Minister. I think somewhere in 2021, there was a contractor from Tumu doing clearing towards Jawia. Since 2022, he has left site, that is from the Tumu towards Jawia. When the Minister said that there is no project from Tumu except the one from Hamile towards Gwollu, the 40 km, I am a bit worried. I do not know where that contractor was from. Actually, there was a contractor.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is your question?

Mr Sukparu: So, my question is, I want to find out from the Minister whether that particular project has been terminated. If not, I am unable to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister, whether or not the project is terminated?

Mr Agbodza: The current programme under the section he is talking about says that there is no programme. I do not know the circumstances under which the grading was done. It could have been routine maintenance work.

Mr Speaker, the records show that we do not have an ongoing contract within that section of the road at the moment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is also a constituency-specific Question. We would move to Question 258 standing in the name of Hon Emmanuel Tobbin, Hon Member for Anyaa-Sowutuom.

Completion of Roads in Anyaa-Sowutuom

Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (NPP — Anyaa-Sowutuom): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads in the Anyaa Sowutuom Constituency will be completed: (i) Agape Road (ii) Kwashibu Road (iii) Fanmilk Road and (iv) Ablekuma Abease Road.

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The Agape Road is an arterial road of 5.2km long which connects the Awoshie Pokuase Road at Ablekuma Pentecost Junction and Gbawe Zero road at Gbawe Gonsee. This is an inter-municipal urban road stretching from Ga Central Municipality at Ablekuma through Gbawe Zero in the Weija Gbawe Municipality. The road is in poor condition.

Current Programme

The road has been awarded under two different contracts with the following contract titles: “Drainage Works along Agape Road Phase 2 (3.65km)-Lot 6” and “Graveling works Along Agape Road (3.5km)-Lot 2”.

a) “Drainage Works along Agape Road Phase 2 (3.65km)-Lot 6”

The contract was awarded on 13th September, 2024 and commenced on 27th September, 2024 for completion by 1st April, 2025. The physical progress achieved is 85 per cent. The Contractor has suspended works due to delay in payment for work done.

b) “Graveling works along Agape Road (3.5km)-Lot 2”.

The contract was awarded on 17th October, 2024 and commenced on 1st December, 2024 for completion by 1st April, 2025.

Warning letters have been issued to the Contractor to return to site.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague is right.

(ii) Kwashibu Road**Background**

The Kwashibu road is 3.5km connecting the Kwashieman-Ofankor road at Santa Maria Blue Kiosk and George Walker Bush Highway at Hong Kong. The road traverses two municipalities, Ga Central and Ablekuma North Municipalities respectively.

Current Programme

The road has been awarded under four different contracts with the following contract titles: “Drainage works on Kwashibu road-0.6m u-drain (2.55km) Lot 7”, Drainage works on Kwashibu road-0.9m u-drain (2.5km) Lot 8, Drainage works on Kwashibu road-1.2m u-drain (1.0km) Lot 2 and “Gravelling works at Kwashiebu (2.5km)”.

a) Drainage works on Kwashibu road-0.6m u-drain (2.55km) Lot7

The contract was awarded on 25th September, 2024 and commenced on 9th

October, 2024 for completion by 10th March, 2025. The physical progress achieved is 37 per cent.

b) Drainage works on Kwashibu road-0.9m u-drain (2.5km) Lot 8

The contract was awarded on 21st October, 2024 and commenced on 4th November, 2024 for completion by 3rd May, 2025.

The physical progress achieved is 52 per cent.

c) Drainage works on Kwashibu road-1.2m u-drain (1.0km) Lot 2

The contract was awarded on 21st October, 2024 and commenced on 4th November, 2024 for completion by 3rd May, 2025.

The physical progress achieved is 30 per cent.

d) Gravelling works at Kwashibu (2.5km)

The contract was awarded on 13th September, 2024 and commenced on 27th September, 2024 for completion by 28th March, 2025.

The physical progress achieved is 95 per cent.

(iii) Fanmilk Road**Background**

The Fanmilk road is 2.7km that connects the Awoshie Pokuase road at

Fanmilk Junction and Amamorley. The road traverses two municipalities, Ga Central and Ga North Municipalities respectively.

Current Programme

The Fanmilk road is part of an existing contract titled 'Rehabilitation of Fan Milk, Amarmorley Road and Links'.

The contract was awarded on 2nd August, 2018 and commenced on 16th August, 2018 for completion by 30th June, 2023. The physical progress achieved is 87 per cent.

The Contractor is currently not on site. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

3.31p.m.

(iv) Abease Road

Background

The Abease road is 2.0km connecting the Awoshie-Pokuase road to Ablekuma Manhean road at Ablekuma Curve in the Ga Central Municipality.

Current Programme

The road has been awarded under three different contracts with the following contract titles: "Drainage works on Abease road-0.6m u-drain (2.0km) Lot 10, Drainage works on Abease road-0.6m u-drain (1.0km) Lot 12. Drainage works on Abease road-1.2m u-drain (0.6km) Lot 12.

Drainage works on Abease road-0.6m u-drain (2.0km) Lot 10 The contract was awarded on 3rd October, 2024 and commenced on 17th October, 2024 for completion by 15th April, 2025. The physical progress achieved is 64 per cent. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Drainage works on Abease road-0.6m u-drain (1.0km) Lot 12 The contract was awarded on 17th October, 2024 and commenced on 1st December, 2024 for completion by 1st April, 2025. The physical progress achieved is 60 per cent. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Drainage works on Abease road-1.2m u-drain (0.6km) Lot 12 The contract was awarded on 1st October, 2024 and commenced on 15th October, 2024 for completion by 13th April, 2025. The project is substantially completed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, thank you very much for reminding all of us.

Any supplementary question?

Mr Tobbin: Mr Speaker, it is not a question; I just want to plead with the Minister or the Ministry to consider an interim maintenance work on the Roads mentioned—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, a plea to the Minister is not for parliamentary record—

Mr Tobbin: No, I am pleading with the Ministry.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you can see the Minister or the Ministry and then you do your plea. That is not for our *Hansard*.

Mr Tobbin: Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are welcome.

Hon Members, we will take the Question numbered 248, standing—Very well.

Hon Minister, we thank you very much for attending upon the House and providing Answers to the Questions. We are most grateful; you are always here to answer Questions.

The next Question stands in the name of Hon Ahmed Shaib. It is for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, who has taken his seat. So, may the Member proceed to ask the Question.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 88(3) and I have the authority of the Member to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You may proceed to ask the Question.

MINISTRY OF LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Permit-issuance System and Tracking Mechanism for Imported Excavators

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu on behalf of Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP —Weija-Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the plans to establish an effective permit issuance system and tracking mechanism for imported excavators to operationalise the directives of the President.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) (MP): Mr Speaker, I rise to respond to the Question posed on the steps the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, in collaboration with relevant agencies — that is the Ministry of Transport, Custom Division of the Ghana Revenue Authority, Ports and Harbours, Driver and Vehicle Licencing Authority (DVLA) , and the Minerals Commission — is taking steps to establish a robust permit issuance and tracking system for imported earth-moving and mining equipment, particularly excavators, in line with the directive of His Excellency the President of the Republic of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the President has been very clear and consistent in his commitment to addressing the scourge of illegal mining and its devastating impact on our environment and communities. One of the critical control measures under this vision is the regulation of

importation, clearance, registration, and monitoring of all earth-moving equipment, particularly excavators.

Mr Speaker, to this end, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, in collaboration with the above-mentioned institutions, has developed a multi-agency framework to streamline the entire process from importation to operational monitoring.

This plan is woven around the Minerals and Mining (Mineral Operations Tracking on Earth-Moving and Mining Equipment) Regulations, 2020 (L. I. 2404), which prescribes the mandatory registration of all earth-moving and mining equipment that is to be used in mineral operations. L. I. 2404 ensures that machinery and equipment are tracked in real time and used only in mining areas for which they have been registered.

Permit Issuance by the Ministry of Transport

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Transport has been tasked with the responsibility of issuing import permits for excavators and related machinery. However, under the new framework, such permits will only be granted after the intended end-use of the equipment has been verified by both the Minerals Commission and the appropriate agencies, as the case may be. This verification will determine whether the importer has a legitimate mining licence or is involved in lawful construction or infrastructure activity. Once that is determined, the permit is then issued.

Custom Clearance and Licensee by the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA)

Mr Speaker, the Custom Division of the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA) plays a pivotal role in this process. Custom officers at all designated ports of entry have been instructed only to allow clearance and get out all earth-moving and mining equipment when an approved import permit is presented and endorsed by both the Ministry of Transport and the Commissioner-General of the GRA. Furthermore, a special clearance code is being developed within the Integrated Customs Management System (ICUMS) to track these permits and ensure accountability at every stage.

Registration and Number Plate Issuance by the DVLA

Mr Speaker, once clearance is granted by the above institutions and the equipment is gated out from the port, the DVLA assigns a special identification number plate distinguishable from the conventional number plates. The inscription on the number plate is green printed on a white background.

Tracking Of Earth-Moving and Mining Equipment by the Minerals Commission

Mr Speaker, to ensure that we have eyes on the movement of each earth-moving and mining equipment, tracking as required under L. I. 2404, each registered equipment is fitted with a tamper-proof Global Positioning System (GPS) tracker. This tamper-proof will

make sure that any time a person tampers with it, it will blow an alarm in the operations room managed by a centralised equipment monitoring and control room, currently set up and operated by personnel of the Minerals Commission.

The control room operates 24 hours every day and can monitor the real-time location and movement history of all registered machines across the country, especially those operating in mining districts. As we speak, this is important, both the DVLA and the Minerals Commission operate a 24-hour office at the Tema Port, where all registration and tracking activities take place.

Mr Speaker, these steps represent a coordinated and forward-looking strategy to sanitise the use of heavy equipment in mining and construction sectors of Ghana. It is our firm belief that, through these institutional collaborations, we will significantly reduce the abuse of excavators in illegal mining and improve environmental governance in our country. We remain committed to executing the directive of the President in full and call on all Members of this House to support these efforts.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister, ever since they put this permit issuance

system in place, the number of permits that have been issued.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I can say that, since this system was put in place, 150 of these excavators have gone through the tracking system at the Minerals Commission. I think the real-time permitting information can be given by the Minister of Transport.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

3.41 p.m.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, in the elaborate strategy to combat the abuse of excavators, he indicated that the import of all of these strategies is to reduce the abuses. My Question to the Hon Minister is, we are in this country; in the event that these abuses occur, what are the sanctioning regime to those who fall foul of these processes?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, without actually quoting the specifics in Legislative Instrument (L. I.) 2404, I can tell the Hon Member that the sanctions regime is all prescribed in L.I. 2404.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the respected Minister if the existing machines: the earth-moving machines and excavators, would also go through this coordinated system?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, that is very important. As he knows, all the focus is on the new excavators that are entering, so there is a completely new regime on the registration of excavators and other equipment that have not been registered, but are already in the system.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw: Mr Speaker, from the Answers of the Minister, he said they are developing a multi-agency framework to streamline the entire processes from importation. I would like to find out from the Minister if this framework would warrant an amendment to the L. I. 2404.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, indeed, as we work along, when there is a need to come to this House to strengthen the current L. I. 2404, we will do so. But I believe that, for example, the requirements to get the controller, the customs officer, to be part of the authorisation is something that I am not sure was envisioned in the L. I. That is one area that we have to strengthen. So, I believe that there are gaps in the L. I. that we would, in the future, come to this House to support.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I tried to understand and to coordinate the very elaborate Answers by the Minister. He mentioned a number of state institutions who are stakeholders in this enterprise. Would the Minister consider a kind of one-stopgap measure,

where at a point, all these institutions would have played a role without necessarily going all over the place, which may mean a lot of labour and would be laborious if he considers a one-stopgap measure.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, that is a very good question. In my Answer, I stated that a special clearance code is being developed within the Integrated Customs Management System (ICUMS) to track these permits and ensure accountability at each stage. In fact, one of the challenges we see now is that because the authorisation comes from the Minister for Transport and the Commissioner of the Customs Division, it creates a little lap in delays in the approvals.

What we are working on now is to ensure that once the approvals have been done, it would go into the ICUMS system. So, for example, when the excavator is finally imported and arrives in the country, we would not need any manual process because the system will already know that this permit has already been approved. What will always be there will be the tracking and the movement, which is also established. Yes, so, indeed, a coordination to make sure we have a one-stopgap is something that we are working on.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I find out from my good Friend that notwithstanding this comprehensive system, we have read recent news that a number of earthmoving machines have been confiscated. Is it the case that even with this comprehensive system, people

are succeeding in evading the system or what is the issue?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I must say that despite the existence of L. I. 2404, frankly, the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority (DVLA) has not been registering those excavators in the system for a long time. That has created a backlog of excavators in the system that could not be tracked. Also, the Minerals Commission was also slow in putting all these excavators in their tracking system because, frankly, they had no control of those that are coming in.

Now that we are aligned with the Ministry of Transport, Customs Division, and DVLA, we are able to get it in the operating room of the Minerals Commission to actually know which excavators are actually coming. So, the problem that has been created was that there were really gaps in the past and those gaps are being closed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 234 which stands in the name of Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin, Member of Parliament for Mfantseman.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Efforts to Ratify the Ewoyaa Lithium Agreement

Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin (NDC — Mfantseman): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the efforts the Ministry is making to ratify the Ewoyaa Lithium

Agreement in the Mfantseman Constituency.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, Barari DV Ghana Limited is a mining company incorporated under the laws of Ghana. In accordance with Section 5(1) of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703), The mining lease of the company was granted on 20th October, 2023 for a term of 15 years ending 19th October 2038.

The lease granted the company covers an area of 42.63 km², located at Mankessim in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

The lease was submitted to Parliament in 2024 and same was considered by the Select Committee on Lands and Natural Resources. However, a report was not written for the House to ratify the lease and the House adjourned for the 2024 general elections. The company has since the beginning of this year written to inform Government of the change in circumstances, which is collapse in the price of lithium. The collapse in the price of lithium and the request by the company to revise the terms of the lease presents a new challenge for the project.

The price of lithium was about US\$3000 before the mining lease agreement was signed by the previous Government in October 2023. The cost of producing a tonne of the concentrate as submitted by the company in its bankable feasibility report was US\$675. However, battery metals markets remain under pressure as falling prices and

oversupply have seen the sharpest decline in prices.

Major lithium producers have cut production, laid off workers and new projects have been put on hold due to the collapse in prices.

Having regard to the cost of producing a tonne of concentrate at US\$675 by Barari and the price at the world market below US\$675 required to produce a tonne of the concentrate, the company submitted a request to the Minerals Commission for the consideration of Government to save the project. The Ministry has notified Cabinet of the request of the company and will be presenting a new memorandum with revised proposals for the consideration of Cabinet and to Parliament thereafter to save the project.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

3.51 p.m.

Dr Arhin: Yes, Mr Speaker. Ewoyaa, where the lithium is deposited, has 499 structures, has 1528 farms—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if you do not have a supplementary question, kindly resume your seat.

Dr Arhin: The question is, Mr Speaker, does the Minister have any update on the progress of compensation for the farmers and the landowners where these places were declared by the Minerals Commission?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Hon Speaker, I was supposed to come and answer questions on the status of the project, especially whether the project is moving forward. I will be happy to come back to answer a substantive question on the status of compensation of farmers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minister. Yes, Hon Kingsley Nyarko?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I thank the Minister for the elaborate responses. With the collapse of the lithium prices, will it still be prudent for the state to pursue this venture?

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Thank you very much.

It is a very good question. Since the company brought this letter, we have received a lot of petitions from chiefs and community leaders, on how important this project will transform the communities in terms of jobs and it is based on this that the Government is looking at this project.

We are looking at the project to see if we can do a scaling scale to basically look at royalties and other performances and adjust it as the price goes up. So, for

example, we were at US\$3,000 when it happened. Is it possible that we can do the adjustment in such a way that we can take royalties back to 10 per cent when the price gets to that level to make a profit? Because ultimately the benefit is not only royalties, but the creation of jobs and other infrastructural development. And we are looking at all of that in presenting a new memo—working with the company. But we are yet to finish that engagement so, as we go forward, we will inform this House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am sure the Minister knows that the volatility of such international commodities at the international market is not far-fetched. However, Mr Speaker, if you will bear with me, lithium and bauxite constitute more than 60 per cent of the raw material components used in the production of solar panels—Lithium and bauxite. Indonesia has a success story we can buy into.

Mr Speaker, would the Minister consider—we have the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST)—notwithstanding the volatility of the price of lithium at the international market, would he consider the development of this sector, which could serve as a source of raw materials to feed the development of solar panels in the support of our renewable energy sector?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that should have been a fresh Question. The Minister is brought here to

tell the House the effort the Ministry is making to ratify the lithium agreement. But you are talking about a different thing altogether from the ratification.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, my deduction is coming from the Minister's Answers. For instance, he has said that the international price of lithium is changing or is going down. As a progressive Member of Parliament, I am looking at what we can do as a nation. But, Mr Speaker, if it is your pleasure, I see the Minister is ready to answer the question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is in response to why the ratification was not done.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, could you find out if the Minister will want to answer the question?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The issue is not about his willingness to answer the question.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I would like to find out from the Minister that what will the country lose if we ratify the signed lease of 2023?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: I do not know whether the Hon Member heard me. It is not so much

about the country. The promoters of the project had written a letter and the argument is that their project is no longer bankable with the numbers that they have now because they based the whole project predicated on the price at the time. And they have said that the price has stumbled from US\$3,000 to US\$675, making it very difficult for them to proceed on the project. So that is really the issue.

The interest of the country is to make sure we really add value to such resources to help transform our country, and that is our interest. And to the extent that this project will help do that, we will always support it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I thank the Minister for Land and Natural Resources for attending upon the House and responding to Questions slated for him.

Hon Minister, you are accordingly discharged.

Thank you very much for coming.

Hon Members, Question time has ended.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, with your permission, I would like to alter the Business of the day by moving on to Commencement of Public Business, item number 8 and

present some Papers while I have the Minister here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

The application is to vary the Order of Business.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we have no objections to that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, At the Commencement of Public Business, presentation of Papers.

Which of the Papers?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: We are looking at the item numbered 8(b) to be taken by the Minister of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. But the Minister is not here, so I wanted to seek your permission to get the Minister for Land and Natural Resources to do it on his behalf.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is the application on the floor.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we will not object, but he owes this House a duty to tell us where the Minister is. So, he should proceed and tell us where the Minister is, and we will support his application.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, the Minister is engaged in some other

Oral Answers to Questions

ministerial job somewhere and that is why he is not here.

4.01 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Rt Hon Speaker has cautioned—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I know the Minister is engaged for our interests, so—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you may know but I am not aware.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is not for the record. So, you can see me after adjournment.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I support his application.

Yes, I support his application. It is just that the mood of the House is not too good, so—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He is trying to make the mood of the House good.

Yes, Minister for Land and Natural Resources?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, there are actually quite a number of them. So, I was wondering if we can do them all together. From Roman numeral 1 to 15; we can take them together.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

PAPERS

By the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) on behalf of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs—

- i. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Kintampo South District Assembly for the year 2024.
- ii. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tatale-Sanguli District Assembly for the year 2024.
- iii. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sunyani West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- iv. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Gushegu Municipal Assembly for the year 2024
- v. (v) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Nanton District Assembly for the year 2024.
- vi. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ayawaso North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- vii. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Abuakwa North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

- viii. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ablekuma North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- ix. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bosomtwe District Assembly for the year 2024.
- x. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Guan District Assembly for the year 2024.
- xi. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Nsawam Adoagyiri Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- xii. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ahanta West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- xiii. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Hohoe Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- xiv. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tolon District Assembly for the year 2024.
- xv. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bekwai Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader? Any other Business?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Yes, thank you Mr Speaker. The Minister has two of his Reports here. So, that is the item numbered 8 (c) (i) and (ii), if we can take it together.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the item numbered 8(c), Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

By the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources—

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Minerals Commission for the year 2024.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Office of the Administrator of Stool Lands for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you. Mr Speaker, the next is the item numbered 8(d) but the Chairman of the Committee is not here. I do not know if I can seek your indulgence to ask a Member of the Committee to actually—*[Pause]*

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, in the spirit of cooperating, the Frontbench can feel the cooperation on their skin.

We are co-operating. If there is a Member—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, in this case, the Chairman of the Committee is rightly at your back. So, if he is not here, you should account for him. This is a Committee chaired by the Minority.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am your Hon Friend.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I know.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: But you are exposing me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I am not exposing you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you are taking me in.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why I am averting your mind from where you are going.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I take a cue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that your Side chairs this Committee.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, the Leader can proceed and get a Member of the Committee, if we so have a Member around, to lay the Report.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we have a Member here who will do it on behalf of the Chairman?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 8 (d).

By the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) on behalf of the Chairman of the Committee.

- i. Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Air Quality Management) Regulations, 2025.
- ii. Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Effluent) Regulations, 2025.
- iii. Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Management of Ozone Depleting Substances, Halocarbons, Halocarbon Alternatives and their Products) Regulations, 2025.
- iv. Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Environmental Assessment) Regulations, 2025.
- v. Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Refrigeration and Air Conditioning Certification) Regulations, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, once again. Mr Speaker, can we now

move to the item numbered 21 on the Order Paper, Motions, which is the Fisheries and Agriculture Bill, 2025?

Mr Speaker, I would like to seek your permission to get the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to do it.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I disagree with the Motion listed 21. Mr Speaker, we only finished the Consideration Stage of this Bill yesterday, and we have not seen the amended Report to see whether those proposed amendments have all been incorporated.

Mr Speaker, I also want to draw your attention to Standing Order 172. Standing Order 172 (1) reads that:

“(1) Where a Bill has passed through the Consideration Stage, the Third Reading shall not be taken until at least one sitting day has been elapsed.

Mr Speaker, we only finished it yesterday. We have not seen the document and the one day has not elapsed. The Minister is not here, so I do not think it is proper for us to take it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I agree with you, except that the Bill is taken under a Certificate of Urgency.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: That notwithstanding, Mr Speaker, with respect to you. The Consideration Stage—[*Interruption*—no, there were a number of times the Minister was not here at the Consideration Stage. The

Minister is a Member of Parliament and so she has to be here.

4.11 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we are opposed to the Third Reading of the Bill. The Minister has decided not to be in the House; she has elected not to be here. The Chairman has always been here. Mr Speaker, we cannot—in fact, we can compromise to do Government Business, but not the Third Reading. They can correct it, that is fine, but we are opposed. Mr Speaker, we take a cue and a lesson from you when these matters come up. The Third Reading, the Minister is not here, and we should just allow it to go? No, that cannot be.

The point the First Deputy Minority Whip made is crucial. Have all the amendments been incorporated? We need to have access to it. Most importantly, the Minister must be in the House. What can be more important than the Third Reading of her Bill? She must be here. The Chairman should step out and call the Minister. He should tell her that she must find her way here. These are the people’s representative; this is the Parliament of Ghana. She cannot place more importance on other business than her own Bill. Third Reading. What is that? Certificate of Urgency, and she is not here?

The President will hear about this. Hon Atta-Mills, get ready; the first reshuffle is coming. Please, get ready. Hajia, get ready for the first reshuffle. Lace your boots for the first reshuffle.

Mr Speaker, we are ready to support them to prosecute Business of Government. In fact, we have been very supportive. Mr Speaker, you would testify that we have been very supportive. But, on this occasion, we are not done yet. We still have Business to prosecute.

The Majority Leader just came in looking very fresh. He should just step out and call the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development to come. Otherwise, the Third Reading will not happen; it is not going to happen.

Mr Speaker, without adding more, we need the Minister in the House. The Majority Leader cannot convince us. I know he is looking at his rules. He cannot convince us.

Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader wants to try his usual tactics. He will combine diplomacy and then he will be jabbing us. No, this one, we will not agree. He should find some other reasons; the only thing that can convince us is to get the Minister here and we will support.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I do agree that when Ministers introduce Bills here, it is proper that they are available to shepherd the Bill through the various stages. Mr Speaker, let us ask ourselves the question of what essentially Third Reading of a Bill is. Does a Minister play any substantive role in the sense that, in the

absence of the Minister, this House misses an opportunity to get the right thing done?

Mr Speaker, we have already gone through Consideration Stage, which is the most difficult, engaging and policy-involving part of the passage of legislation. Third Reading, by Order 172 of our Standing Orders—If I may read this. It says:

“(1) Where a Bill has passed through the Consideration Stage, the Third Reading shall not be taken until at least one sitting day has elapsed.

(2) Upon a Motion “*That the... Bill be now read the Third Time*”, any Member may move an amendment to delete the words “*read the Third Time*” and to insert the word “*rejected*” and to move a reasoned amendment, stating the object and motive on which the opposition to the Bill is based, but the Motion must be strictly relevant to the Bill.

(3) The Clerk shall read aloud the Long Title of the Bill, if the Motion for the Third Reading is agreed to, the Bill shall then be taken as read the Third Time and passed.”

Mr Speaker, the Minister, apart from moving the Motion, does not really have a substantive role that will, in any way, go into the essence of the Bill, especially

when we have finished the Consideration Stage.

Mr Speaker, in this instance—And I know this Minister; one, she is a Member of Parliament and would ordinarily have been here as a Member of parliament. And two, she is a Minister of State and I have observed her; she participates in the proceedings of this House. Indeed, she is one of the Ministers who the Minority Leader consistently has questioned why she is here, instead of being at her Ministry working.

I have heard the Minority Leader, several times, ask her why she is here instead of being at her Ministry? So, this is a Minister who would have been here. But on this occasion, she is attending the World Fisheries Congress in, I think, Italy. She is representing us in Italy at the congress. We would have ordinarily waited for her to return before we would take this Bill through all the processes, but it also because we have a deadline and that was why when the Bill was introduced, it was introduced under a certificate of urgency, so that we could meet that deadline. So, we cannot wait for her to return from the congress.

Mr Speaker, I am pleading with my Friends opposite that they should allow the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to move the Motion on behalf of the Minister, so that we can have this Bill passed to meet the deadline.

I am pleading with them; they should let us allow the Motion to be moved by the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib?

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, we strongly disagree with the Majority Leader. Mr Speaker, if the Majority Leader looks at page 8 of our Order Paper, even though another Minister, with your permission or leave, could have moved the Motion. But if you read our Standing Order very well in 172, it is very clear. The Standing Order 1721 says:

“Where a Bill has passed through the Consideration Stage, the Third Reading shall not be taken until at least one sitting day...”.

We finished the Consideration Stage last night at 9.00 p.m. The Majority Leader was here, so we have not been able to satisfy that provision in our Standing Order.

Mr Speaker, even when we finished the Consideration Stage, the proposed amendments that have been done have not been incorporated. We have not seen the Bill: what was amended and what was proposed. None of us have seen the Bill. We do not even have a copy of it to satisfy ourselves as that has always been the case.

Mr Speaker, the practice of this House—You have been a senior person when it comes to drafting of these Bills. Mr Speaker, last night you presided. We left here around 9.00 p.m. We have not seen it; whether they are finished with incorporating what was amended into the

Bill, we do not know yet and we are rushing into a Third Reading.

Mr Speaker, we can take it tomorrow. Tomorrow, when we all see and know that the amendments have been done, then we can do it. Mr Speaker, doing this one will offend our Rules; it will offend the practice of this House and I do not think the Majority Leader should let us rush ourselves to go through this.

If the Bill is so urgent, the Minister is not here and the Majority Leader said she is in Italy. Even if we do the Third Reading, where will she be to sign it? What is the rush? Where will she be to even—*[Interruption]*—No, she definitely has to sign it before gets to the President— **[Some Members of the Majority: No!]**—So, who takes it to the President?

Mr Speaker, with respect, I do not think we should rush this. The Minister is not there; she should come tomorrow. We will do the Third Reading, but doing it today will offend the very Rule that the Majority Leader quoted. It will offend our practice in this House and we should not rush it. We only finished it at 9.00 p.m. last night. The Majority Leader was here and I saw him here when we were leaving. The Speaker presided, so we should not—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member of Parliament for Tolon, I have always been drawing your attention to the fact that the Bill is taken under a certificate of urgency. If a bill is introduced to be taken under a certificate

of urgency, it may be taken through all the stages in one day. So, I have a problem with your view that Order 172(1) should apply. Because if you read 172(4), exception has been provided with reference to Order 160 and Order 160 talks about taking a Bill under a certificate of urgency.

4.21p.m

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: In this House, we have often agreed to disagree. And for the love of our country, Mr Speaker, the respected Majority Leader has made copious appeal to us and we respect him.

So, we will give in to that—*[Interruption]*—Yes, I heard him. We will give in to that, so they can proceed with it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, before the Minister moves for the Third Reading, let me, once again, introduce the students from Smartest Starters Kids Academy from the Effutu Consistency, the constituency of the Minority Leader. So, my dear students, the Minority Leader will take very good care of you. *[Hear! Hear!]* So, you are in safe hands.

Yes, Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, you may move the Motion numbered 21.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I beg to move—

Mr Mmieh—*rose—*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, hold on.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 171(1) of the Standing Orders to move that the Bill passes through a Second Consideration Stage to enable me to propose an amendment to clause 128(1)(c) of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the leave for a Second Consideration Stage is hereby granted.

[Pause]

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, with respect, we have engaged with our Colleague, so if we can proceed to the Third Reading. He had a conversation with the Chairman of the Committee and the Chairman would engage him further on this issue. So, we can proceed to the Third Reading.

[Pause]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, with your kind permission, we can have the Minister for Education move the Motion numbered 21.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Education, you may move the Motion numbered 21.

BILLS — THIRD READING

Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) on behalf of the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture: Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025 be now read a Third time.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025 — *read the Third time and passed.*

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, if we could take the item numbered 20. The Motion to take the University of Development Studies (UDS) Bill through the Third Reading.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we have no problem allowing the Minister for Education to take the Motion. However, there is an important matter that the respected Minority Leader just whispered to me. There is a Statement that has to be taken and the two Leaders have spoken—*[Interruption]*—Majority Leader, we would do it for you; do not worry.

So, the Hon Minority Leader will present the Statement, after which we would proceed to take the Motion, then we would do a Second Consideration of the—*[Interruption]*—Yes, but we want

to first take the Statement. No, Majority Leader, do not worry; we would do it for you. The Majority Leader has been here before; he has been at both Sides before. When the two Leaders agree, I cannot disagree.

So, Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader would present the Statement, after which we will revert to the—*[Interruption]*—That is the agreement. I am told that is the agreement—*[Interruption]*—All right.

Mr Speaker, with respect, after the Third Reading, then we would take the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but you were at Conclave and the agreement that we reached, you may correct me, was that Statements would be the last item for today. Is that not what we agreed on? Once that was what we agreed on at Conclave, whatever the Statement, it will be taken today. But we agreed that Statement will be the last to be taken.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I take direction from the Leaders in this House. We, in Leadership, must help you to navigate and steer the affairs of the House. Where the two Leaders have agreed on something, I cannot differ. Regardless of a decision prior taken at Conclave, the Leaders have agreed.

So, Mr Speaker, with respect, shall we proceed to take the Motion after which we would revert to the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Minister for Education, you may move the Motion numbered 20 at page 8 of today's Order Paper.

4.31 p.m.

BILLS — THIRD READING

University for Development Studies Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the University for Development Studies Bill, 2025 be now read the Third Time.

Minority Leader (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The University for Development Studies Bill, 2025 — *read the Third time and passed.*

Alhaji Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, but he just said at Conclave that he agreed on Statements as the last item. No, Mr Speaker, he should listen carefully. I was not at Conclave. Yesterday, he approached me and said he had a Statement and I supported. So, I asked him to just clear it with the Speaker. He said, no, he wanted to clear with me first. I said, I have no problem.

Mr Speaker, he said that his Statement is about the Ablekuma North by-elections and incidents of violence. I

said, it is alright. If anything happens publicly and we want to discuss it, let us discuss it. I supported. I said, I have no objection; he should come and make the Statement. But as for Conclave, I was not there so, if at Conclave the agreement was that, yes, he could make the Statement, but it should be the last item, how will I—It is Speaker, who is drawing attention, not me. I cannot override the Speaker; I am not the Speaker.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, I need the Leader's attention. Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader is certainly not the Speaker. The Majority Leader was not at Conclave. He was not at Conclave and when he came, he made several applications that we should vary the order of Business and we obliged him. A while ago, less than a minute, we had agreed that the Motion would be taken by the Minister for Education. Then we will revert for the Statement to be —What is this? Mr Speaker, the Leader should not do this. No.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, this is important and seriously, yesterday, we met outside there and he told me, he wanted to make a Statement on the violence in Ablekuma North and he needs my support. I told him I support him, but he should let me see a copy. In my presence, he called his Personal Assistant (PA), and directed his PA to make a copy available to me to read before the Statement is made. His PA promised to make a copy available to me.

Mr Speaker, as I sit here, I had not seen the Statement. It is right now that he has called the PA to remind the PA to bring the Statement to me. I support him making a Statement, but I thought that I have a responsibility to at least peruse it, because there may be issues that I have with the content of the Statement. So, when he even said they agreed the Statement should be made at the end of Sitting, I thought, this is a welcome development, because it gives me time to peruse the content of the Statement before he makes it.

Mr Speaker, as I sit, I have just started reading, and I have seen a few paragraphs. Names of individuals have been mentioned, accusations against them made, accusations that are of a criminal nature, and even calls for their indictment being made in the Statement. They are not here, and I am just seeing it for the first time and if I am going to do anything at all, I am going to object to the Statement being made, because I thought it was going to be a general Statement about, you know, the violence and *et cetera*, which we all have seen in a few by-elections, so that we can all condemn it, and then we can advise the nation. But there are specific names of people that I know who are being accused of having engaged in violent conduct, and that this House should call for their indictment, this House should call for their dismissal. I am just seeing it for the first time. So, I even have objections to this Statement being made. I do not know if the Speaker has seen the Statement. As for content, it depends on the facts.

If you go and prove the facts in the court of law, if you raise them here, then as a House, we may have to cause an enquiry to be conducted in this House. So, Mr Speaker, honestly, I was trying to buy time to really go through it and then see if there is anything that will create problems for all of us. Otherwise, I have no objection. I promised him yesterday that if he has a Statement, he should come and make it. So he should not think that I am trying to resign from an agreement that I had with him.

Mr Speaker, I do not know if you have seen this Statement. I am seeing it for the first time and he is here. The cameras saw when his PA came and handed the envelope to me with the Statement. That is my problem, Mr Speaker. So I plead with him to let us move on to other Business while I go through it. If I have issues, I will draw his attention. If we really would omit those ones, then we can have the Statement made.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I would want to be diplomatic. Hon Minority Leader, probably after doing Business, I may request you to see me briefly. Then we can come back and take the Statement. Based on Standing Order 93(2), I have some issues to discuss with you on the Statement.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Government Side, Frontbench, the Speaker is asking for indication.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Indication from the Frontbench.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, you may just take a very short suspension so that we can deal with this issue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, we may take a short suspension. The House is accordingly suspended for a few minutes.

4.38 p.m. — *Sitting suspended*

5.35 p.m. — *Sitting Resumed*

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN THE CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, you are welcome back from suspension.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think the understanding we have is that the Minority Leader has to attend the meeting, so if we can vary the Order of Business for him to make a Statement and then we can take the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Statement on the incidence at Ablekuma North Parliamentary Rerun, standing in the name of Minority Leader, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin.

You have the floor.

Hon Member, I think we gave a ruling the other time, so you may use your seat to take the Statement, with all due respect.

[Pause]

Yes, Majority Leader?

Hon Majority Leader, let me hear from Hon Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, the last time you gave a ruling on the fact that the Minority Leader used the despatch box in asking Questions.

Today, the Minority Leader would want to make a very important Statement. He is the Leader of our Side, and he remains the arrowhead, and the despatch box on the left is ours. Mr Speaker, even though you have given a ruling that at Question time, the despatch box must not be used, I crave your indulgence, that this must be clearer, and I seek your guidance.

Mr Speaker, this Statement is on behalf of the Caucus. We are all aware of what has happened at Ablekuma, but when the arrowhead is leading us, none of us can give any contrary view. So, I pray that—to deny him of using the despatch box is almost saying that the Minority despatch box cannot be used. That is the meaning, because this is a very important Statement. So, I pray—

and because he is doing it on behalf of the Caucus, and the despatch box on your left remains our despatch box, I pray, that you direct—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, my ruling is very clear. It was captured by the *Votes and Proceedings*, as well as the *Official Report*. Anybody who is aggrieved by that particular ruling, the grievance procedure is also spelt out in our laws.

I have the instance of reading through the Statement and making my modifications to the Statement. I do not see this Statement as one being delivered on behalf of the Caucus. I have even mentioned that this particular Statement being delivered by the Minority Leader, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin. So, with all due respect, to now say that a Statement is being delivered on behalf of a Caucus, probably you may get hold of a copy of the Statement and indicate to me where it was clearly stated that this is a Statement being delivered by the Caucus. I did not see any Caucus position in the Statement when I was reading through. So, with all due respect, my ruling still stands in matters of this nature.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I do not intend to challenge your ruling or argue with you, but I thought that it would have helped if you had listened to us. Once we finish, then you sum up your ruling. Maybe you may or may not change it.

Mr Speaker, if I do not say this, I will not be fair to the Minority Leader. Yesterday, the Minority Leader

indicated to me that he would want the Deputy Leader to read this Statement on behalf of the Caucus. I was the one who convinced him and the God who created us bear witness to me that I sat here and convinced him that, no, there are certain Statements that he should make himself.

He then argued that, no, he does not want it look like every Statement is being read by the Minority Leader. And I said, no, he should do it on behalf of the Caucus. So, I just want to supply this information for you to know that he wanted somebody else to do it, but we insisted that he should read it on behalf of the Caucus.

Mr Speaker, I would say that you may make your ruling, but the fact is that this Statement is being made on behalf of the Caucus. It is not a personal Statement. That is all I wanted to say.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, you are a former Leader of this House. Let us turn to the rules and look at Order 91—Statement by Speaker and Minister. Order 92 is talking about Ceremonial Speech; then Order 93 is talking about a Statement by a Member.

The Statement that you are talking about, how does it feature in our Standing Orders, that is Statement on the floor of Parliament?

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, this Statement is not—Let me read, “Statement on incidents of lawlessness at Ablekuma North Parliamentary Re-Run Election by the Minority Leader Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin”.

The man is the Minority Leader; He did not say by Hon Afenyo-Markin.

There is a reason he used the words “by the Minority Leader”. He is doing it on behalf of the Minority—*[Interruption]*—And as I said, it may not qualify, Mr Speaker. It may not qualify as an official Statement.

But to take the right of the Minority or even the Majority Leader from using the despatch box for Statements on behalf of the Caucus, I think it is going too far. Maybe Questions, I understand; the other day, we all spoke about it. But when it comes to making a Statement on behalf of the Caucus, I think that the person should be allowed to use the despatch box. That is the despatch box for the Minority.

5.45 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, you would realise that, the day I was compelled to give a ruling, I even called upon you to speak. I pleaded that we should let it go and then we will have a meeting involving the Speaker; to have a guideline on the use of the despatch box. That was completely ignored and I was prevailed upon to deliver a ruling and I have so delivered a ruling.

So, I have a clear difficulty calling on me to depart from the ruling I have delivered. So, now, we should have the wisdom as to why I said there must not be a ruling and that we should involve the Speaker, so that there can be a guideline on the use of the despatch box, but that was not taken. I was prevailed

upon to deliver the ruling and I have so delivered the ruling within the context and with my understanding of the Rules.

So, having done that, if it is not a ceremonial speech, you are not concluding a debate on the Budget Statement or the Message on the State of the Nation, then I believe, as a Member rendering a Statement, whether a Majority or Minority Leader, you stand at your designated place and make the Statement and I will invite Members to comment equally on the Statement. So, this is my view. It is not everything that you should be urging upon the Speakers to rule on. Do you understand? Every day, you insist the Speakers rule on something and I have ruled on that.

Yes, Hon Member?

STATEMENT

Incidents of Lawlessness at Ablekuma North Parliamentary Re-Run Election

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make a Statement on the incident of lawlessness at Ablekuma North parliamentary re-run election.

Mr Speaker, the violent incident that occurred and marred the parliamentary re-run election in Ablekuma North requires condemnation. This House and, indeed, the nation must take very seriously the coordinated act of violence, intimidation and lawlessness that occurred on 11th July, 2025. These events present one of the most dangerous assaults on our democratic order since return to constitutional rule in 1992.

Mr Speaker, this was not merely an electoral misconduct. What happened in Ablekuma North was a calculated military-style operation targeted at disrupting our electoral process and intimidating political opponents. If left unchecked, it risks normalising political violence in our democratic culture. Mr Speaker, permit me to highlight some of the deeply disturbing incidents.

Firstly, at St Peter's Society Methodist Church polling station, a group of thugs stormed the premises on motorbikes and in vehicles. Hon Hawa Koomson, a former Member of Parliament (MP), was physically assaulted in broad daylight. Our parliamentary candidate, Nana Akua Owusu Afriyie, sustained some injuries to her face. Former MP, Darkoaa Newman, and several other New Patriotic Party (NPP) agents were also attacked. Electoral officials fled and voters were terrorised.

At Awoshie Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority (DVLA) polling station, individuals dressed in brown uniform impersonated security personnel to gain access and misled voters until they were confronted and they failed, in that instance, to provide any form of identification. Elsewhere, including Asiedu Gyedu Memorial School, confrontation between thugs and police officers created chaos and endangered lives.

Even journalists were not spared, Mr Speaker. A *Joy News* reporter and Agyekum Banahene of *GH One TV* were attacked. In fact, a police officer assaulted the latter while on duty. Mr

Speaker, this is a direct attack on press freedom and the right of citizens to be informed. These were not isolated events. This was a deliberate orchestration of violence across multiple polling stations. And what is even more troubling, Mr Speaker, is that some officials have not only failed to condemn these acts but have celebrated them openly and publicly.

Mr Speaker, for those public officers who have endorsed this political violence, I say that it is a breach of public trust and a dangerous precedent that undermines democratic foundation of Ghana. Equally disturbing are the growing concerns about the negligence of the Ghana Police Service (GPS). Allegations have surfaced implicating Chief Superintendent Lumor Frederick Senanu in facilitating this act. Whether by omission or commission, the Police Service failed to protect lives and the sanctity of the electoral process in Ablekuma North.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's democracy is at crossroads. We must not allow this dissent into lawlessness to define our politics. That is why the Minority Caucus demands the following:

A full-scale investigation into the matter.

A full-scale prosecution of individuals who will be identified as perpetrators of the violence.

A clear and unambiguous condemnation of the violence from Government, including apologies to those who

were particularly victimised: Chris Lloyd Nii Kwei, the Deputy National Organiser, Hawa Koomson and our candidate Nana Akua Owusu Afriyie.

Mr Speaker, we must not allow political violence to become normalised. Ghana's democracy must not be turned into a battlefield. The time to act is now.

To the people of Ablekuma North, do not be cowed into silence. The right to vote is sacred and must never be trampled by fear or force. To civil society and all defenders of democracy, your voices are needed now than ever. The Minority Caucus, Mr Speaker, will continue to use every constitutional means available to it to protect Ghana's democratic order and ensure that no political actor ever weaponises violence for electoral advantage again.

Mr Speaker, our country, Ghana, stands at the crossroads. Government must choose and uphold democratic values or shelter those who undermine them. The choice Government makes, in the coming days, will define this legacy of this Government and the direction of our democracy.

May God bless Ghana and strengthen our republic and Mr Speaker, I thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much for your Statement. The floor is now open.

Leadership, any indication as to the number of Members to comment on the Statement?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I just had an eye-to-eye chat with the Majority Leader. So, we will do five on each Side and Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let me hear from you.

5.55 p.m.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I think we will do 10 each. We have so many people here who want to speak.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the sense of the House?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any difficulty. We can take 10 contributions from each Side and Leadership. If they want, we can do our 86 plus Leadership, no problem. So, we can take 10 from each Side and Leadership, Mr Speaker.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: All right, Mr Speaker, please, let us keep it at four contributions from each Side since we have a Bill to work on.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Does that include or exclude Leadership?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, excluding Leadership. Leaders will conclude.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not know why the Deputy Leader is hijacking the first indication I gave after I conferred with the Majority Leader. It

was five contributions from each Side and Leadership. Unless it is the case that the Majority Leader is now giving him a different thing, but my understanding with him was that we would take five contributions each and Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if I got it clear, their proposal is that it should be five, including Leadership. That is my understanding.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I have so many people here who want to comment, so let us do three-five—*[Laughter]*—Three from the Minority Side, then five from this Side. Let us be equitable. Try and be equitable. Three on their Side and five from our Side—*[Interruption]*—No, Mr Speaker is asking for guidance; he says we should guide him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, ladies first. I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Hajia Laadi Ayamba.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by the Minority Leader.

Mr Speaker, first of all, I wish to condemn all forms of violence, no matter where and no matter what time. It is most unfortunate that this is the first time I have heard in my fourth term in Parliament that after the numerous electoral violence that has occurred in this country, this is a special one. I would have stayed off mentioning the name of my sister, Hawa Koomson, but once her

name is on the Statement and it has been mentioned, I will do that.

Mr Speaker, Hon Hawa Koomson knows very well that apart from the atrocities that have ever occurred in her own constituency, where lives were lost, if she went to that very election and came out without any problem, it would have all come from her attitude. Yet, I was shocked when I learnt that she used pepper spray. Pepper spray! And I saw her actually spraying it.

Mr Speaker, in the video, I looked at it more than five or six times and I saw her actually spraying it. I was shocked because I observed and listened to people who said that she is a woman and a lady; we should not do that and we are not respecting women. Yes. We are all trying as much as we can, to make sure that women are respected everywhere, but she, as a woman, must first of all respect herself.

She must make sure that she knows and lives as someone who is ready to support and protect lives as a woman. If she says because she is a woman, she goes about spraying pepper, was she going to select the women there, so that the pepper does not get into their eyes? What about the children? Was she going to select them? What about the officers that we are now talking about? Was she going to select them? This is because any pepper spray that is gushed out will not select anybody. Yet, this was what happened. Unfortunately, it came from no other person but a woman.

Mr Speaker, are we saying that this is the first time that we have had such a problem? This is not the first time. I was a victim at the Atiwa by-election. I ran back to Accra like it was no one's business. *[Laughter]* So, it is not the first time. I never heard a word being uttered.

Mr Speaker, what did we not see at Techiman South? What lives have we not lost? Lives; we lost lives. What investigations have been done? Who has been brought to book? What have we done to make sure that Ghanaians know that, at least, once we are running a democracy, we do not want such atrocities? What have we done? Nothing. Were they not human beings? Were they not Ghanaians? Were they not voters? Do they not have the right to life? Yet, we have not heard anything up till date.

Mr Speaker, at Ayawaso West Wuogon, we witnessed even our own Colleague, Hon Sam George, being beaten. Sam George of all people. He received the worst slap that anybody could have thought of. And till date, we have not heard anything about it. Those whose legs were broken have, today, become vegetables of human beings. They are just there. They are just living and waiting on others to give them to feed. We have not heard anything. No Statement; nobody has said anything. It looked like it was just some flies that fell somewhere.

Mr Speaker, we cannot forget about Awutu Senya. We cannot forget about what happened there. The shooting was direct, not that it was a “go-come” matter. Odododiodoo; all these are things

that have happened in our presence and in our lives. If we want to condemn and to be seen as doing the right things and ensuring that our democracy thrives, we should make sure that it is not a selective thing. It should not be selective. If we are being selective, it is not fair.

6.05 p.m.

Yes, I agree that what happened yesterday that was wrong, should not be done today because two wrongs do not make a right. That is true. But it is not when you continue pinching my eye that you tell me that I should not close it. Every day you do the same wrong to me, I keep quiet, and then you think that I should never say anything because you think that, no, you are right, so I should not say anything? That is not acceptable. It is unfortunate that it is a woman and it is unfortunate that it has recurred, not from any other person but someone who has ever done it somewhere. Let us be careful and conscious. She is a former Minister.

Today, we are calling for the heads of women who are Ministers or women who are Chief Executives. Was she not a Minister?

Let me reiterate that she is not someone whom I would wish to stand and talk against. But when something is wrong, like you have said, it is wrong; and it is not acceptable—*[Interruption]*—Yes, I am saying this because it has happened before and happened to me. It is the same thing that is happening. If we do not let her know that it is a kind of worry, it could repeat

itself, and we do not want it to be repeated.

Mr Speaker, to wind up, let me say that what is good for the goose is good for the gander. So, let us be conscious of ourselves. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I would want to thank the Hon Minority Leader, Osahen Afenyo-Markin, for making this important Statement in the House.

Mr Speaker, the Statement is very important because this unwarranted lifestyle continues in the country. This has been happening to politicians. The two main political parties are in this Chamber. I am sad today because we should come together as a House and make sure that this is stopped in the country, and it does not continue.

Mr Speaker, this must not be business as usual. I have witnessed and heard a number of atrocities being committed in the country. We have had by-elections at Talensi and Chereponi. I was an eyewitness of the by-election that we held at the then Atiwa Constituency on 31st August, 2010. Yes, also in Ayawaso and other other places.

Mr Speaker, I can speak to what I have witnessed. I was at Atiwa, and I saw with my naked eyes that thugs were in a bus. The main thing they were doing was to go around and beat people just to prevent others from voting. The person being

beaten could be a brother or a sister or it could be anybody.

Mr Speaker, we must come together as one people and fight this. When things had gone on in this House, we made a law. We made a law that we have to dismantle vigilantes. After the passage of the law, it still continues. I was in this House when I heard a statement like “violence begets violence”. I would not want to remind anybody of names.

But I am saddened because we tried to justify this unholy act in the name of elections. We tried to justify it because in the name of elections, people are dying and we do not care. In the name of elections, people are injured and we do not care.

Mr Speaker, I am glad that the Minority Leader requests that there must be a full-scale investigation into this.

Mr Speaker, with you—
[Interruption]—Mr Speaker, I need your protection. With a great deal of respect, I need your protection.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are a 100 per cent protected. You may proceed.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I pray that we must come together as a House. I would not want to react directly to what my Sister has said. But in this full-scale investigation, we would know, as a country, what we have to keep on ourselves by way of protection. I would have thought that under normal circumstances, a lady having a pepper

spray in her bag would serve as a form of defence when a person is being attacked—[Uproar]—

Mr Speaker, if we do not fight this, it would not end today. Everything else had been on hearsay. I would not want to go on with the circumstances that led to the usage or non-usage of the pepper spray. That is why I pray, Mr Speaker, and I support the maker of the Statement that there must be a full-scale investigation into this act that happened in only 19 polling stations that we were conducting elections.

We cannot say that because the people who had been beaten were on the side of one political party, and I belong to the other political party, I have to support the unwarranted behaviour that had gone on.

Mr Speaker, I pray, we must come together as a House, and it is only in this House that we can stop what is going on. Otherwise, it may lead to a time that we cannot control the situation. Mr Speaker, I support the request of the maker of the Statement, that there must be, either a committee or a special *ad hoc* committee to go into this. Then we look at how we can put brakes or eliminate this behaviour from us as politicians. That is the only thing that can save this country. We have passed the law; it did not work. Let us come together—

Mr Speaker, I know that if we go on, at every by-election we have situations and if it is not against the New Patriotic Party (NPP), it is against the National Democratic Congress (NDC). If it is not in favour of the NDC, it is in favour of

the NPP. But we cannot continue like this, when others are suffering.

Mr Speaker, let us get into this and find solutions to this problem.

6.15 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will proceed to give the floor to Mr Felix Kwakye Ofofu.

Mr Felix Kwakye Ofofu: Mr Speaker, the unfortunate altercation which occurred at the Ablekuma North by-election made for very difficult viewing. It is something that nobody can defend. But, Mr Speaker, I recall that in the early 2000s, when I first set foot in this House to look for then Hon Minority Leader, Rt Hon Alban Bagbin, who now is the Speaker of this House.

Mr Speaker, he gave me a copy of Geoffrey Bing's seminal work, "Reap the Whirlwind". Little did I know that that title was actually a famous biblical verse, which says you have sowed the wind, and you shall reap the whirlwind.

Mr Speaker, let me place it on record. I was a student at Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Ofofu—

Mr Ofofu: I was a Tertiary Education Institutions Network (TEIN) executive. But Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are not supposed to answer anybody.

Mr Ofofu: Well, it was just by the way.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us listen to each other in silence.

Mr Ofofu: A critical test must be held on anything that Members of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) say in respect of this particular incident and it is a test of sincerity.

Mr Speaker, if we carry out a cursory examination of the positions taken by our Friends sitting on the other Side, on the many acts of impunity and raw terrorism which occurred between 2017 and 2024. Very few or none of them would have been heard condemning those incidents. No sooner had they come into power than they formed groups with blood-curdling names, such as: "Invisible Forces, Delta Forces" and what have you.

Mr Speaker, we witnessed a situation where in 2019, during the Ayawaso West Wuogon by-election, State sponsored thugs—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with my Colleague, I tried to listen to him carefully. Mr Speaker, I am relying on Order 93(5) and further on Order 123(2).

Mr Speaker, my Colleague used the word "terrorism" and relying on Order 93(5), he is not supposed to provoke

debate. He could proceed with his submission, but I implore you to impress upon him to withdraw the word “terrorism”. Mr Speaker, it is totally unparliamentary and this House should not be entertaining such unparliamentary words and, Mr Speaker, I invite you to let him withdraw that word used. It is totally unparliamentary, and it is offensive to our Rules.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think that, as a general practise, I have avoided trying to intimidate first-timers anytime they are speaking. I try very hard. Even when they make mistakes, and we have to point it out, I find a way of doing that and I do not want us to encourage a practise of intimidating first-timers. The Rules are clear not to provoke debate. How does the mention of a word “terrorism” provoke debate?

Mr Speaker, the issue of terrorism in electoral campaigning engaged this House to a point where we had to enact a legislation on the matter. So, when he is given a historical account and simply refers to the word “terrorism”, how does that provoke debate? It does not. So, I urge you, Mr Speaker, let the contributions continue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please continue.

Mr Ofofu: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. There is no doubt that what the thugs associated with the NPP did in Ayawaso West Wuogon and in places like the Kumasi courts where they barged in and freed their Colleagues standing trial amounted to terrorism.

Mr Speaker, terrorism is simply the use of violence to achieve political ends. What is most worrying is that any time those thugs got into trouble, it was officials of the NPP who went to their aid.

Mr Speaker, at the time, nobody on their Side read a Statement here that we should condemn those actions. Mr Speaker, whereas I sympathise with what Hon Hawa Koomson went through and there is no way I will condone that kind of conduct, she herself has been historically involved in acts that pass for violence during elections. She admitted publicly to firing guns at polling stations during the 2020 limited registration exercise.

Mr Speaker, we know that there are members of the NDC who today have been maimed. Some have actually lost their lives out of violence that she is believed to have instigated. When one does these things, the person calls violence upon himself or herself. So, I agree in principle that firm action has to be taken to stamp out this spectre of violence that has characterised almost every by-election in our country. But let not those who in the recent past were sponsoring these acts of terrorism against opponents suddenly pretend that they are against it. They are not.

Mr Speaker, in all the eight years that they remained in power, what concrete action did they take in the many acts of violence that took place? There is a Commission of Enquiry report which identifies individuals who are known members of their party and says they

should be sanctioned for the wrongs that they did.

Mr Speaker, the Emile Short Commission identified specific individuals for prosecution. No sooner had that report come out than their Government issue a white paper insisting that those gentlemen engaged in those acts of terrorism because they were provoked.

Mr Speaker, a party that endorsed violence during elections cannot come today and call for investigations into acts of violence. It is those of us who condemned it in the past and are condemning it today who have the right to make such a call.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Oforu: So, even in the wake of the events at Ablekuma North, their officials are on record to have vowed that there will be violence at Akwatia. Even as they call for action to be taken, they are threatening violence.

Indeed, we all recall that in 2012 the then candidate Akufo-Addo openly praised the use of violence as a political tool. When he said, “*Atiwa, yekyerε biribi kakra wɔ hɔ*”. Mr Speaker, the same Nana Akufo-Addo is on record to have said, “all die, be die”.

Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please, conclude.

Mr Oforu: Hon Kennedy Agyapong went on public radio and called on Akans to attack Gas. Mr Speaker, when he was prosecuted and released by a court, they carried him shoulder-high and poured powder on him to celebrate those comments. People with this kind of record cannot possibly purport today to be opposed to terrorism and acts of violence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Oforu: Mr Speaker, let us have a discussion about sanitising our politics, but let us eschew insincerity and duplicity in the discourse. Let us take firm action against those—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

6.25p.m.

Mr Oforu: Who threaten violence at elections, but let us not accept hypocrisy.

Let us not accept the politics of convenience that, today, it is Hawa Koomson and so all hell must break loose.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Oforu: Mr Speaker, I am for strengthening the laws against electoral violence. Let the law take its full course, no matter who is involved.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes Hon Nitiwul?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, I want to lend support to my Leader for the Statement that he made and I do so knowing that, Mr Speaker, as you all know, I had the privilege to serve as Minister for Defence for eight years and one of the cries, not just cries, but big concerns of my Friends on the opposite Side was the fact that people were violent and that we should do something about it.

In fact, at every least occasion, they made sure that they made the whole world to understand that there was violence, whether it was election or a gathering, especially when we had opposing views. I am very surprised today that after complaining like that and getting power for only seven months, they would unleash this type of violence in a by-election where we have just 19 polling stations. They asked the then President, Akufo-Addo, to do something; he enacted a legislation. The NPP had vigilantes just like them, but we disbanded all of them—[**Some Hon Members of the Majority:** *Ei!*]*—*That is why they did not see them at Ablekuma.

Mr Speaker, they should remember they are in government. The safety of every citizen is in their hands. It is no more in the hands of the people over here. It is dangerous for people in government to be justifying violence,

especially by Ministers of State. The best they can do for the people of Ghana is not to speak. In fact, the best they can do for the people of Ghana is to ask the police to go out and arrest the people. I am happy that this is live and Ghanaians are watching—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order!

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, some people have forgotten. I will remind us. He knows—Those who have been here for long know that, in the Chereponi by-election, it is not someone, I witnessed an individual take a gun and shoot three people. Mr Speaker, if not for the expertise of Prof Kwabena Frimpong-Boateng, those three people would have lost their lives.

Mr Speaker, I was at Talensi by-election; we had to run for our lives. I was a polling station agent both in Chereponi and Talensi and we had to—Even though I was a polling station agent, I had to run for my life; thugs came and started shooting.

Mr Speaker, at the Ayawaso West Wuogon by-election, the same thing happened. People had to run for their lives; some of them here run for their lives—[*Uproar*]*—*People here also run for their lives.

Mr Speaker, in Atiwa by-election, I was with my Colleague, Hon Kobby Darko-Mensah in the car with Hon Asiamah, the former MP. When we got to a polling station, the young men blocked us and they started shouting,

“*ɔmoreba*”, so they should beat them. And when they saw the NPP flag, they said, “We should go”. Mr Speaker, when we asked them why, they said that they had brought thugs from Accra—*[Interruptions]*—Mr Speaker, the young men at the polling station told us that people had brought thugs from Accra and they wanted to teach those thugs a lesson.

Mr Speaker, when you add up all these incidents, from the 2000 to the 2016 elections, the people of Ghana, including the Majority Side, said we are all tired and that we should do something about it. We came to this House to enact a legislation to disband all vigilantism, only to see that the NDC—Maybe, it is not the NDC; that is what we are calling—Mr Speaker, only to see thugs at Ablekuma attacking people—*[Interruption]*—Listen, this Statement is not about Hon Hawa Koomson. We will not allow anybody to make it a Statement of Hawa Koomson.

Mr Speaker, the trade of all of us sitting here is in the business of politics: searching for votes and convincing people. We can all be victims. Mr Speaker, we do not know the next person; we have a by-election. If we do not do something about it, we do not know who the next person will be. Today, it is Hawa Koomson and they are gloating over it. They are happy and jubilating; we do not know the next victim

Mr Speaker, I support the Minority Leader when he says that we should investigate in full, just like it happened

for the Ayawaso West Wuogon by-election where we set up a Commission and people appeared on television and we saw the people. We are asking the President to do the same. Mr Speaker, in the Ayawaso West Wuogon by-election, a Statement was made on this floor; the NDC demanded full investigation and the Government complied. Why are they running from investigation? Why are they running away from conducting investigation? I want to state that we all saw the videos.

Mr Speaker, the polling station, which is the Methodist polling station where Hawa Koomson and her other colleagues were attacked, had close to 70 police officers. By the time the attack came, the police officers were over 30 and these vigilantes were able to overpower state actors; that is the sad part of it. Mr Speaker, if young people do not respect uniform which is authority and can attack a politician, it does not matter whether it is Hawa, Nitiwul or Ayariga. But the fact that a policeman is wearing uniform and young people can attack that person means we are all endangered species.

Mr Speaker, it is sad and frightening; they may be joking but when one allows people to think that they have been pushed to the wall, one does not know how they will react. It is sad and we are joking. This country is a peaceful country. We should not allow a few individuals to disturb the peace of this country. We should not allow a few individuals to destroy this country. I go around looking for votes and that is my business. So, if we have said that we

cannot allow violence at the polling stations, so be it. How can we, as a country, say there are 19 polling stations and we allowed violence—

6.35 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, this is a very important Statement. Let us all be sober and reflect because if we do not, I always say—My Colleagues opposite, who have huge numbers in Parliament, should remember that they are in Government and anything bad that happens is their record.

Any black dot is their record. If somebody dies in an election, it is their record. If somebody is maimed, it is their record. If somebody is beaten, it is their record. They should, please, disband their vigilantes. If they do not, they will be asking other people to form vigilante groups and we would not know the end.

Mr Speaker, I said that Parliament should immediately—If the Executive is refusing or does not get its act together and launch a full-scale investigation, then Parliament should do it. This is because we know the faces of the individuals behind the crime. We know all the faces. The police should go; crime does not have an expiry date. It can be hundred years; crime does not have an expiry date—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Nitiwul: I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Edem Agbana, you have the floor.

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to this very important Statement about election-related violence and the course for justice.

Mr Speaker, as a Member of Parliament, I join all discerning Ghanaians who are condemning the violence that we saw at Ablekuma North last week Friday. Violence in an election is a threat to our democracy and we must all join hands to ensure that Ghanaians can go to the polls and vote for people that they wish to lead them without coming into contact with any act of violence.

However, I find it very intriguing that the call for justice and the condemnation of what happened at Ablekuma North is coming from the Minority Side. I say so because just like my Hon Colleague, Mr Felix Kwakye Ofosu has said, under the New Patriotic Party (NPP) regime from 2017 to 2024, we saw how almost every election organised under them was characterised by violence and not just violence; state-sponsored violence.

Mr Speaker, I stand in this House today as a survivor of the January 2019 Ayawaso West Wuogon by-election violence. I went to the Legon Hall polling station as a national executive of the National Democratic Congress (NDC), properly accredited by the

Electoral Commission. I had no weapon, not even a pen or paper and no pepper spray. I only went to the polling station as a national executive accredited by the Electoral Commission to observe elections.

But, Mr Speaker, men clad in national security apparel moved to me and attacked me. They did so in the presence of the military and that is why I am surprised that the former Minister for Defence, under whose watch we saw the military used for such pettiness, could today be demanding for investigation. What did he do when he was Minister for Defence?

Mr Speaker, right in front of the military, the police and NPP national executives I was attacked. I have records of the voices and pictures of NPP officials who praised and even mocked Sam George and I that they could have done better or that the thugs should have beaten us better.

Mr Speaker, I condemn violence, but my point is that, he who calls for equity, if he cannot come with clean hands, at least, he should hold a hand sanitiser. What happened to the recommendations of the Ayawaso West Wuogon by-elections? Today, if they sit in this Chamber to pontificate and pretend as though this is the first time—Mr Speaker, like I said, I went to the polling station with no weapon; yet, I was attacked.

Mr Speaker, again, in 2020, I was in Techiman South as an observer. I saw how people in military uniforms opened

gun fire on NDC supporters. The videos are there and I can share for the records. If today, the preaching in this House is as though it is the first time we have seen—Like I said, I also support the call to condemn violence. However, like I said, those who are calling for justice should remember that just like the former Minister said, crime has no expiry date.

There are victims of the Ayawaso West Wuogon violence of whom today, some have been amputated and are demanding for justice. All the families of the eight people who died in the 2020 elections, their families are demanding for justice. Mr Speaker, the families of the people who were brutalised in Banda during registration because they were voltarians and they were being prevented from registering right in front of us are demanding for justice. The families of the people that were brutalised in Kasoa, including the people that Hawa Koomson herself admitted shooting at, those families are equally calling for justice.

If we want to see an end to electoral violence, as all of us are preaching, Mr Speaker, let us stretch our hands in the investigative process and bring to book those men who are even easier to identify because they were in national security uniform. It means it was a state sponsored vigilantism. All of them must be brought to book and that level of terrorism in our elections will stop.

Mr Speaker, I have seen that President Mahama is different. President Mahama is different because in his first 100 days, he instructed the Inspector General of

Police (IGP) to open investigations into the killings in the 2020 elections. We are told that the reports are ready. President Mahama is committed to ensuring that everybody who has been a victim of any electoral malpractice or violence will get the justice that they deserve.

Mr Speaker, I conclude by calling on the House, especially discerning Members of the House, to join me to pay a minute of silence in memory of Tuariq and the eight people who lost their lives in the 2020 elections and all others who lost their lives.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

[All Hon Members of the Majority Side rose]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Kindly resume your seats.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

6.45 p.m.

Mr Kwabena Boateng (NPP — Ejisu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on this important subject matter. I would like to also commend the learned Leader for making this important Statement.

Mr Speaker, we know that 11th July, 2025, will go down in history as one of the dark days of our democratic journey. It is also the case that the event will also constitute a take away from our democratic credentials. Anybody observing from an impartial stance or from international observation will come

to an irresistible conclusion that what happened is a minus in our democratic practice.

Mr Speaker, more worrying is when we would see fellow human beings reviewing the lives of their fellow human beings to a conclusion that they deserve an affliction that has occasioned them.

Mr Speaker, I was surprised to have seen my Senior, the Member of Parliament for Pusiga, a female, who boldly reviewed the life of a fellow woman and came to a conclusion that she deserved the affliction that has come upon her. Mr Speaker, I think that when men want to fight, they fight their colleague men. Mr Speaker, you do not find men who fly in the air with all their strength in their bodies only to attack a woman. Mr Speaker, it is also shameful when you would find leading Members of Government —

Rev Ntoso — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, I am pleading with them, but your language is so offensive. *[Uproar]*

Yes, Hon Ntoso, you have the floor.

Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso: Mr Speaker, probably the Hon Member did not listen well when Hajia Ayamba was speaking. She did not attack — *[Uproar]*—

Shut up over there! Shut up!

Some Hon Members — rose —

[Uproar]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed, you do not control the House, so you need to be recognised to speak. I am not happy about your gesture. Please, kindly resume your seat.

Rev Ntoso: Even though you are a Leader, I am your Senior; you should know that.

Some Hon Members: Ohh! Ohh!

[Uproar]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, address the Chair.

Rev Ntoso: I am a senior, and so — Mr Speaker, Hajia Ayamba was telling this House the facts about what happened. During their time, Hon Hawa shot at people. So what she was saying was not an attack, but a fact of what actually happened. So they should not say that she attacked Hon Hawa. She did not attack Hon Hawa. She was just telling us the truth, and nothing but the truth. Because an eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Hon Member, your conduct violates the rules. *[Uproar]*

Mr Ayeh — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member!

Hon Members, with all due respect, if you do not have the floor, if you are not

given the opportunity, you have no opportunity to speak. You are only allowed to speak when you catch the eye of the Speaker. It is therefore very disorderly to just get on your feet and begin speaking. When such a thing happens, I will not hesitate to ask the Marshal to walk you out of the Chamber. *[Uproar]*

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Please, continue. Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you will not determine what I should say. Mr Speaker, we have a responsibility as Leaders to help you manage this House. Mr Speaker, a while ago, I had drawn your attention to Order 123(2), the word “terrorism” was used in this House, and you allowed it to pass. Mr Speaker, a while ago, my Colleague asked a Member, she spoke into the microphone, “Shut up!”. Mr Speaker, we do not want this House to degenerate. I have been calm listening. Mr Speaker, we want to pray your wisdom. If the Marshal will be called —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, what I intend to do is that I do not foresee comments on this Statement generating debate. So, if you would not mind, after the Hon Member is done, I will let the Leadership conclude so that we end comments on the Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I was trying to make a point, and when you came in, we need to listen to the Speaker in silence, so I had to resume my seat. I had drawn your attention earlier to Order

93(5) which is clear; Order 123(2) is also clear. But Colleagues are making interventions that are offensive of these Orders. Mr Speaker, I earlier tried to catch your attention. We do not want the House to degenerate. And you have warned that anybody who goes contrary to the Orders, you are going to call the Marshal. I hope it will apply to both Sides of the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, sure.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I hope it will apply to both Sides of the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is not a warning to one Side.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I thank you. Then we shall proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Leaders — Hon Member, go ahead and conclude your comment.

Mr Boateng: Mr Speaker, it is obvious, and we can state so emphatically, without any ambiguity, that the mayhem that we witnessed in Ablekuma North is one that is likely to be state sponsored. Mr Speaker, I say so because after the event —

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Boateng: Mr Speaker, after the event —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader?

Hon Member, please resume your seat.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, like I said earlier, as a Leader, I should not in any way intimidate or heckle a first-timer. But let us just be careful. When he says it is one that is likely to be state sponsored — when he mentioned state sponsorship—Mr Speaker, you noticed that when the Minority Leader was going to make the Statement, I objected. You noticed we spent close to an hour in Conclave. There were similar statements in the Statement. He deleted them. You are my witness. He deleted them. We agreed on the text, and we objected to certain things. He does not have proof so he should not accuse the whole state. So please, he can make his comments, but he should avoid such imputations and trying to use a broad brush to just paint a whole state.

I beg him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, be guided accordingly.

Mr Boateng: Mr Speaker, respectfully, the point that I am making is that I have no doubt in my mind that Government is complicit in the activities that occurred, the mayhem that occurred.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I ask that you should be guided accordingly.

Yes, Majority Leader?

6.55 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think that he has to withdraw. He has to stay away from what he is saying. Mr Speaker, we are all trying to manage a situation. There are things that we can say. The NPP as a political party announced that they were not participating in the election.

They announced as a political party that they will not participate in the election rerun.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: What were they looking for at Ablekuma North? They announced that they were not participating in the election rerun and then we find them there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you will have your turn to comment.

Mr Ayariga: Do they know the implications for announcing that they were not participating in an election?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you will have your turn to comment.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I beg you. When one announces that they are not participating in an election, what it means is that they put the security agencies to sleep—*[Interruption]*—Let me tell them, if they have run the security agencies before—as security agents

when they project that the full scale of NPP and NDC are going to be confronting each other in 19 polling stations, their security preparation in anticipation would be different from when they are told that NPP will not participate. Their party announced it. They organised a press conference as a political party and announced that they will not participate—*[Interruption]*—Is it a deliberate ploy by the NPP to create chaos and mayhem in the election rerun?

Why would they announce that they will not participate in an election only to go and participate? Why would they do that? Then when there is a security situation, they turn around and say that that security situation is state-sponsored. How could it be state-sponsored? I say he must withdraw that. They cannot say that the state of Ghana or the Government of Ghana is complicit. Mr Speaker, he has to withdraw that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the respected Leader makes a point that the NPP said they were not participating in the election and we put the security agencies to sleep. That is an indictment on the security agencies of this country and the Government.

First of all, he should do a reasonable deduction of his own statement. It is not only NPP as a political party that is a stakeholder for the election that was rerun at Ablekuma North. So, if he says that NPP, stayed out and therefore we caused the security agencies of this

country to go and sleep—Has the Leader thought through his statement well? Maybe he should consider it again.

Mr Speaker, in any case, the Majority Leader did not see anything wrong when the respected Hon Ofori said between 2017 and 2024 that there was terrorism in this country under the watch of the NPP—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, we owe it as a duty to state the position clearly. I agree that there has been too much background noise as a result of which when a Member is commenting, I have a difficulty picking the full words of the person—*[Interruption]*—But what I heard was that what happened at Ablekuma North constitutes terrorism. That was what I heard.

Mr Anoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, that is why I earlier premised—Mr Speaker, my ears are always attentive—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It may be sharper than mine. *[Laughter]*

Mr Anoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, my ears can never be sharper than yours, but the point must be made. It was said, my Colleague said, he can deny it, but we can call for the audio. He said that in 2017-2024 under the watch of the New Patriotic Party, there was terrorism. Now, he did not find that offensive and he is calling for a withdrawal of a statement.

Let Hon Ofori do the needful by withdrawing that statement and then we

can also think about whether we can withdraw that statement or not. We have not offended any of our Orders. We have not. Leader, we have not.

In any case, our decision not to contest the election rerun, is not his business. He has said that our decision not to contest the election put the security apparatus of this country to sleep. What? Mr Majority Leader. We can give him the option to think through this statement and come again because it is flawed. It is disappointing to come from a whole Majority Leader and I do not expect him to say this.

Mr Speaker, our Colleague has stayed on course. He has not offended any of our Rules. When the Member spoke into the microphone and said that he should shut up, clearly offensive of Order 123(2), when they were provoking debate, offensive of 93(5), Mr Speaker, you were quiet.

Mr Speaker, we are quiet watching you and the Majority Leader is on his feet saying that the security apparatus of this country went to sleep because NPP said they were not going to contest. Anyway, Mr Speaker, we are in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he does not know the security apparatus in this country. I have experienced them in real violent situations in elections. The week before the general election, there was persistent gunfire in my constituency. I

could not even come out of my house. Not what they are doing. Not this child's play at Ablekuma North. Real—
[*Interruption*]

Mr Speaker, please, let me tell you the story. Please pay attention, it is very important. The Northern Commander called me and said, he had received very bad reports about Bawku. He wanted to meet me at Bolgatanga. All the NPP and NDC candidates were in Bolgatanga. They were all there and he said that there is no security situation in a general election that they cannot handle.

None in this country that they cannot handle but they will not come because NDC as a political party has said that the party does not want soldiers at elections so, for that reason, they would not get involved. But if I say they should come, they will come and the election will take place. I told him I will take responsibility so they should come to Bawku. He said that they will go back, prepare and come.

A day before the general election, the soldiers moved to Bawku with full force that I have never seen before. Early in the morning, they took position in every corner of Bawku and everybody was free, went out, voted and came back home.

They counted—[*Interruption*]—

7.05 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the election in Bawku was the most peaceful in the whole of Ghana. The most peaceful election that I have ever seen in my life in Bawku was

this last election. You can ask anybody who is in Bawku and they will tell you.

Mr Speaker, that is why I said that if you want the security agencies to ensure the safety of everybody in an election and you give them the right indications and the signals and they prepare and deploy, I can assure you that it will be the safest election. But when you misinform them and because of the misinformation, they prepare based on what they anticipate, you will find lapses.

Mr Speaker, that is why I said the Minority Side misled them. They gave everybody an indication that they were not going to participate in the election. And then behind the scenes, they came and said they were participating in the election at a time that they had not deployed in anticipation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Leadership should conclude with the debate.

Hon Majority Leader, thank you very much.

Hon Member, conclude with your comments.

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, I am happy to know from the Leader of the House that the conduct of the elections—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, go ahead and conclude your comments.

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, respectfully, my utter disappointment is

in the fact that leading members of our Government, after the event which we are all lamenting about, went public and endorsed an attack as if a section of our populace deserved that mayhem visited on them.

Mr Speaker, in this House, all that I have heard is a recount of, so to speak, an attribution of a crime to Hawa Koomson, the former Hon Member of Parliament. Mr Speaker, our laws are very clear that if somebody commits even the highest crime of the land, there is a due process to put that person through and not to hire people to fly in the air to headbutt the chest of a woman to the floor. Mr Speaker, I think that is very inhuman, to say the least.

Mr Speaker, as we know the law to be, crime does not die. So, if the former Hon Member has committed anything that we deem to be a crime, the proper recourse is in putting her before the law even as we speak and we have a Government in place. Mr Speaker, I do not think that we have done well by assaulting her in the manner that we did and same being applauded by members of the Government is very appalling.

Mr Speaker, I am also disappointed by the fact that elements within the party and appointees of Government, who in the first place, prevented the Electoral Commission from collating just three polling stations—They prevented the Electoral Commissioner from doing that. Mr Speaker, how did they do that? Any time the Electoral Commissioner was ready to do her work, we found appointees that went on social media and

publicly called thugs to march to the office of the Electoral Commission and, in no time, these people armed to the teeth were sitting on motorbikes and ready to visit mayhem on the EC and the officers there.

Mr Speaker, what will happen? Obviously, the officers of the EC will run through the windows to save their single dear life. And that is how the Electoral Commission had to do the u-turn that they did. I know they are not proud of the decision they took. They are not proud because they had to take it out of force and enormous pressure being brought to bear on them by the Government.

Mr Speaker, if you have prevented them from carrying out the lawful orders of a high court and we are to go for a rerun, and we find those same appointees and elements within the Government also publicly marching thugs to disrupt the re-run of the elections. And Government says nothing about it, and nobody has lost their job even as we speak. Then, Mr Speaker, what it means is that the EC cannot collate three polling stations and the EC cannot also do a proper re-run because people will march thugs to go and disturb the process. Mr Speaker, this is a difficulty that we should all be very worried about.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, we also witnessed that, well, maybe, deliberately or inadvertently, the police that were sent there to man the elections had no weapons; they had no guns. They were

not armed. Can it be for a reason, so that the thugs, when they march in and armed to the teeth, will be able to overpower the police? Mr Speaker, that was what we saw on our television and for some of us who went there, that was what we saw. We saw the police helpless; we saw that the police could not do anything because they had no weapons.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, we know that the mere sight of a gun handled by a police officer can dispel people with criminal mentality—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Boateng: Mr Speaker, I think that we have not done very well for ourselves and across the political divide, we should come to a certain consensus. We should come to a certain consensus to enforce the laws that this House has passed by way of a statute. Mr Speaker, this is a call for all of us, not a partisan one. It is a call for all of us to do so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, with these words, I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Leaders, my decision is to allow the leaders to conclude their comment, with all due respect.

So, Minority Side, I expect you to conclude the comments.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I can see the Majority Leader on his feet; I do not know if he wants to vary the Order of Business.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Yes, so let us conclude because we have some Government Business to prosecute.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip, you have the floor.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: My pleasure is to yield to Hon Awuah to speak for and on behalf of the leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon member, you have the floor.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, all we have heard this evening is that it happened in Atiwa, so it is all right if it happens in Ablekuma North. It happened in Chereponi, so it is all right to happen in Ablekuma North. Mr Speaker, it happened in Ayawaso, so it is all right to happen in Ablekuma North. Let us all look into our faces; today, by the grace of technology, everybody is watching us.

Are we, as leaders of this country, saying that we are ready to practise retributive politics? Is that what we are saying? Are we saying to the many

children who are watching us that when we promised the people of this country a reset, we were going to pursue retributive politics? This is not what they promised. Is this what they promised? Perhaps, the people of this country should have been guided. They should have been guided by the fact that they have stated that, for them, revolution is in their blood, so they were going to offer revolution; it is in their DNA. That is what they are going to offer.

7.15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I have a few questions. When the police went to Ablekuma North without arms, what informed it? When we all agreed to pass the Vigilantism and Related Offences Act, 2019, was it a decoy? Was it a decoy to surprise us in the 2024 elections and subsequent elections?

Mr Speaker, that is what it seems now. That when they got us to pass the Vigilantism and Related Offences Act, 2019, it was just to surprise us. That is what it seems. They did not approach it with candour, with the same degree of sincerity with which we approached the passage of the Vigilantism and Related Offences Act, 2019.

Mr Speaker, we need to bring this to an end. We cannot continue along this path. One day might be a bad day. This thing has gone on for so long. I was in Ablekuma North. I have lived through this in Kumasi, when we were always terrorised and intimidated from the days of Nana Kwesi Agyemang, who mobilised macho men to snatch ballot

boxes using the 64th Infantry Battalions, the commandos. We remember all those; we have not forgotten.

Mr Speaker, where are we going? The Committees for the Defence of the Revolution (CDR) have come a very long way, so we should agree to end this. The approach requested by the Minority Leader is the way to go. Mr Speaker, having passed the Vigilantism and Related Offences Act, 2019, if we do not do anything in the face of it, that law will fall into dissimilitude; that law will become useless.

Mr Speaker, this is coming right at the back of the Vigilantism and Related Offences Act, 2019. We should, in the circumstance, have an enquiry to determine why this happened and to punish the perpetrators, so that it serves as a proper deterrent. Otherwise, going forward, we are going to have a problem.

Mr Speaker, today, we have been told that what happened in Ablekuma North is child's play and this is coming from the Majority Leader. A journalist was slapped and we say it is child's play? A woman was assaulted and we say it is child's play? Mr Speaker, we are not surprised. Clearly, from the account of the Majority Leader, there is a certain orientation towards electoral violence, so anything is child's play.

Mr Speaker, the children and mothers of this country are calling for an end to this. If this continues, one day, we may wear black in this country and that will not be child's play. Enough is enough.

Thank you very much. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Ms Millicent Yeboah Amankwah (NDC — Sunyani West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity given me.

Mr Speaker, I am very happy to be here as the youngest Member of Parliament and to meet this Statement made by the Minority Leader. Ghana is the beacon of democracy and—[*Uproar*]

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am surprised that men like this, a young lady like that—Mr Speaker, why, are they envying this Side? They should give her the opportunity. I beg them, they should let her speak.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have just listened to the Leader of Government Business and our own Leader. I have always said in this House that we must be very tolerant and listen to one another. I have also encouraged the Backbench; it has been my call to encourage them to participate in the deliberations and to also act in a manner that would make it easy to receive the cooperation of others.

This is because, Mr Speaker, advocacy on the floor of this House does not come easily. It is not easy. It is the reason, some time ago, I even suggested that though our Standing Orders say that we should not read copiously from our notes, at least, as a House, we should allow for Members to come here with their prepared submissions and read them because in an advanced democracy, that is what they do.

Mr Speaker, I would call on my Colleagues to yield to what the Majority Leader has just said. However, he who comes to equity must come with clean hands. Therefore, as this Side will be quiet to listen to the submissions of our respected Lady Colleague, I pray that in future, Members on the other Side, particularly the Backbenchers who have gained notoriety—

Mr Ayariga —*rose*—

7.25 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, all right, I will withdraw that one. Mr Speaker, I withdrawn it.

Mr Speaker, you see, these are matters for Leaders, but listen to the noise they are making; yet, their Leader is making an appeal. Would they keep quiet, humbly? I am calling on them to be quiet to allow their Lady to speak; now, they are heckling me. As a first timer—[*Interruption*]—

Mr Speaker, this Side of the House will yield to the call and yield in silence, but I will plead that in future, our Colleagues must also return such a gesture by listening to our Side, particularly the young ones, so that they improve on their advocacy.

Mr Speaker, this is a big lesson. Mr Speaker—It is alright...

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Ms Millicent Yeboah Amankwah (NDC — Sunyani West): Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, indeed, I am the youngest, but then—[*Uproar*]—[**An Hon Member:** How old are you?]

Mr Speaker, when you get to the Constituency—[*Uproar*]

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader? [*Uproar*]

Hon Worlanyo, may you remain silent.

Mr Ayariga: This is a fact. What are you going to do about it? She is the youngest.

Ms Amankwah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, particularly if your Leader is on his feet, I do not expect anybody behind the Leader to be talking.

Yes, you have the floor.

Ms Amankwah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. As I said earlier, Ghana is a beacon of democracy and during elections, electoral violence should be condemned. No matter the Government, either NPP or NDC. But then what is very important is that we as leaders, our comments before, during, and after elections are important and so we need to be extra vigilant in making comments before, during, and after elections.

Mr Speaker, on this Statement on Ablekuma West—[*Uproar*]—Ablekuma North—Mr Speaker, it is one thing we should condemn because of the violence that it came up with. But notwithstanding, we will commend the security forces that came quickly to the aid of the former Member of Parliament. But this is a call to us as Members of Parliament, since we are discussing it here, that the Vigilantism and Related Offences Act, 2019 (Act 999) that we passed, we should check and amend it. We should tighten up any loopholes in it. Because I believe that if it had been done well, we would not be here discussing this matter.

Mr Speaker, again, one thing we should also be aware of, is what our Member of Parliament earlier said, that H.E. John Dramani Mahama is so concerned about these past occurrences that when this happened, he quickly came out with a Statement. And today, we also have a female Vice President who is equally concerned and has condemned the violence during this process. I believe that with what they have exhibited, this Ablekuma North issue that happened and the previous ones will be investigated and justice will prevail.

Mr Speaker, before I end, I would say that Members of Parliament should be extra careful with their comments because those are what generate the grassroots to get themselves involved. But we should not forget that after those comments, we would go to our houses and get somebody's innocent children into this mess and at the end, some will

be arrested, some will be at the hospital, and some would even, out of that, die. What do we do as Members of Parliament? And I am very happy that today, the youth, which I am also a part of, are learning from this.

Today, because it is the former Member of Parliament, a Statement is being read on the floor of Parliament; what about the innocent ones? Because they do not have titles or are not known outside there—Mr Speaker, please, I would urge Members of Parliament, when we go out for elections, we should be careful what we tell our grassroots and people who follow us, not to get themselves involved. And this is a big message to our constituents. No leader, and I repeat, no leader should encourage them to get themselves involved because at the end, they would find themselves wanting, and those persons would be somewhere else.

I would thank the maker of this Statement, and before I end, it is not only elections. Some comments—Today we are talking about female matters, any comment that would rise—Harassment and intimidation all piled up and got to this point. But let us not forget that Ghana is a hallmark when we talk about peace and better democracy.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity given to me. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, any indication?

We come to the conclusion of that Statement?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, when the Minority Leader makes such a very important Statement, it is only respectful of my Colleague, the Minority Leader, that I conclude the comments on the Minority Leader's Statement. It is only respectful, Mr Speaker. I believe that the Minority Leader would like to be respected by me saying one or two things about his Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you had the opportunity, you yielded. But if they are mindful, I can give you only two minutes.

Mr Ayariga: That is so, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Two minutes.

Mr Ayariga: Yesterday, when the Minority Leader approached me, that he was going to make a Statement about Ablekuma North and the violence that took place there, I indeed encouraged him and expressed my support and said he should come and make the Statement. I assured him that I would join him to condemn the violence; I gave him that assurance and I intend to keep my word and join him and I believe many well-meaning citizens, including the sitting Vice President of the Republic, have all condemned the violence.

Mr Speaker, the violence is condemned by this Side of the House. We condemn it. Nobody wants violence. Nobody should encourage violence. Indeed, for those of us whose vocation depends on elections and having it

peaceful, we should be the first to condemn violence in any election, no matter the circumstance. So, Mr Speaker, I join the Minority Leader to condemn the violence.

Mr Speaker, again, every crime is a crime. Whether the crime took place during an election, after an election, or in any circumstance, a crime is a crime. When there is evidence of criminality, I have always advocated that the state agencies take decisive steps to deal with it.

7.35 p.m.

When Donald Trump lost the elections and his supporters marched to the Capitol, they pursued them one after the other, prosecuted them, imprisoned some, just to send a signal that that kind of behaviour is not acceptable in a democracy.

So, Mr Speaker, it is the duty of the law enforcement agencies, if they have evidence of crimes, to pursue it. I support any call for investigation by the law enforcement agencies. People say probe. What is a probe? There were police officers. It happened within their jurisdiction. It is just 19 polling stations. Why can they not investigate what happened and where there is any criminality, they deal with it as a simple crime? When we elevate it to a commission of enquiry, then parties mobilise behind their various supporters and we all begin to defend the indefensible. I do not think this is a matter for commission of enquiry. It is a simple thing. The police were there.

Somebody said, they were there, but they were not holding weapons. It is not even commendable for policemen at polling stations to be holding weapons.

Normally in elections, the army or those holding weapons are at specific locations, vantage points. But the policemen at polling stations do not hold weapons. There were cameras. We know what happened. Indeed, the incident that we are all discussing is captured. There is a video of it. We all saw what happened. If we are calling for investigation, let them investigate. If we are calling for prosecution as a House, let us do so. That is my position on the matter. I am pleading with you.

But again, I said something earlier, and the Minority Chief Whip tried to create the impression that I spoke ill of the police or security agencies by saying that they were put to sleep. Please, as a political party, be decisive. If they are running an election, run it. If they are not, they should not run.

Mr Speaker, I have read social media reports of the NPP as a political party taking on their candidate and I have seen the candidate also apologising for defying her party and participating in the election rerun.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Leader, kindly conclude.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, as I said earlier, the police need to estimate the level of violence or potential of violence of a particular activity in order to determine what level of mobilisation,

deployment, how much resources to invest in monitoring a political exercise. When they are given the wrong signals and they do not prepare well, we will have such situations.

So, as I call on the police to up their game, I also feel—Honestly, having experienced their involvement in managing very difficult situations, I have confidence in them, they and the military, that they can withstand any situation. They can handle any electoral situation in this country, but we need to give them the right signals so that they also prepare properly.

So, I am not ready to really condemn them for whatever has happened, because I think that we misled them in terms of their level of preparation. Not that they did not have the capacity, but we misled them and I am being very frank about this.

So, I thank the Minority Leader for the Statement and even more, I thank him because when we went into Conclave, we raised issues about certain parts of his Statement, and he graciously deleted all those and presented a Statement without the areas that we on this Side felt uncomfortable about and I think that the Statement was well delivered. Comments were made; a few emotions raised. But I think that that is how this House functions. After this, we will continue to be friends.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. Statement time is ended. Any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I would like to move on to the item numbered 15 on the Order Paper.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister responsible for Education, you may move the Motion numbered—

Yes, Hon Jerry Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I thought that the normal practise is for the Leadership to have some kind of conversation on this. We are unaware of the item numbered 15.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, we indicated clearly, it was even agreed at Conclave that we are not going to take Statements. From Questions we would do Business. However, there was a need to vary in order to do the Statement before the Business. So, I do not think that there should be an element of surprise in this matter.

Mr Shaib: I thank you for indulging me. But I was also thinking that looking at the mood of the House, the numbers and the fact that we are quite exhausted, you were going to have this adjourn for tomorrow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

It is no longer an element of surprise, but it is a request for adjournment.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker I thought we had agreed on us allowing—We varied the order of Business in their favour. So, I beg him and there was a clear agreement.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if you realise, I was going out and coming in. Mr Speaker, a lot of the Backbenchers, we engaged. This Side and that Side. I have always been their advocate and they know—*[Interruption]*—

Well, if they do not want me to speak for them, I will resume my seat. Should I? Thank you. If they do not want me to speak for them, if they talk, I will sit down and they will perish in silence—*[Laughter]*—Because, Mr Speaker, I stepped out. Hon Apaak, do not be where you are to intimidate them, please—*[Laughter]*—They are serious matters.

Mr Speaker, the Backbench from both Sides engaged me. And they said that the Minister was here yesterday. They stayed with him. They did his Business for him. Today, he has come again at this odd hour that they should again do his Business for him. Am I doing the right thing—*[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, so, I would want the Minister to engage the Backbench properly. To get their cooperation. We know how industrious they are. Yesterday, through their industry, the Minister had his UDS Bill through. Through engagement, we get results in this House. Please engage the Backbench. Encourage and assure them that their industry will be appreciated—

[Hear! Hear!]—So that they give him the cooperation. Is that not what you want?

7.45p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister responsible for Education, you may move the Motion numbered 15 on the Order Paper.

BILL — SECOND READING

Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, I call on Hon Colleagues to support Government to provide a legal framework for regulatory oversight over the award of scholarships in our country in order to reduce what has become a challenge for what was established as a scholarship secretariat in working to eliminate political patronage, corruption, nepotism, and cronyism associated with the award of government scholarship.

Mr Speaker, the authority is to ensure that government scholarships are awarded for skills upgrading programmes and pursued in institutions over the country. Government is elevating the scholarship secretariat into an authority.

Hitherto, Mr Speaker, the scholarship secretariat has always been under the Office of the President. To allow for more accountability and transparency in its activities, Cabinet decided that the scholarship authority will now be placed under the supervision of the Ministry of Education.

Mr Speaker, one unique aspect of this Bill, apart from the regulatory oversight, is the fact that Parliament itself, appreciating the difficulties the secretariat was going through due to lack of legislative backing, had an extensive discourse on this matter. In a debate calling for reforms of the scholarship secretariat, as captured in the Parliamentary *Hansard*, fourth series, volume 97, number 50, dated Wednesday, 5th April, 2017, Parliament discussed the need for the introduction of a Bill in Parliament to regulate the administration of scholarships in the country.

Mr Speaker, before I conclude, let me highlight two important innovations in this Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025. One is to allow for the President of the Republic to award scholarships in promotion of cultural exchanges and for purposes of international cooperation, you may be awarded a scholarship.

Another integral part of this scholarship will be a decentralised regime for the administration of scholarships in the country. It will support young persons undertaking undergraduate, postgraduate and PhD programmes. And, Mr Speaker, emphasis will be on merit. And emphasis

will be on the human resource requirement of the country to advance the development of our country.

Mr Speaker, in concluding, there will also be the President's scholarship for excellence. This will not be a matter determined by the political figure or political heads. Every year, when the West African Senior School Certificate Exams (WASSCE) is conducted, the West African Exam Council (WAEC) will make a determination of ten best students in West Africa and Ghana. And all those ten students in Ghana will qualify for the President's Meritorious Award for Excellence.

Mr Speaker, I beg to *move* and urge colleagues to support the Ghana Scholarship Authority to provide regulatory oversight for the award of scholarships in Ghana and to work in collaboration with the Students Loan Trust and other agencies of state to ensure that those who deserve scholarships are ones who get it.

Mr Speaker, as I am speaking to you today, many Ghanaian students have just been sent home, some in their final years of study abroad because of government inability to honour its pledge and to fully pay for the scholarships that were provided them.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved. The Chairman of the Committee on Education may present the Report of the Committee on the Bill.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I second the Motion, and in doing so—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, this is Second Reading. You are called upon to present the Committee's Report.

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I beg your leave to submit the Report of the Joint Committee on Education and Public Administration and, State Interest on the Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, I wish to appeal that the *Hansard* captures everything in the Report as I present the introduction and the conclusion. But before that, on page 9, item 9, clause 20, I wish to appeal for *Hansard* to capture it as “moneys approved by Parliament for scholarships in the Ghana Education Trust Fund formula”; formula was omitted.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025, was presented to Parliament by the Hon Minister for Education, Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu, in accordance with the 1992 Constitution, and read for the first time on Wednesday, 9th July, 2025. Subsequently, the Bill was referred to the joint Committee on Education and Public Administration and State Interest for consideration and report in accordance with the standing orders of Parliament.

Mr Speaker, the joint Committees, having scrutinised the Bill, proposes the following amendments for the consideration of the House. And in conclusion, we urge all Members to support the Bill so that we can pass it within the shortest possible time.

Mr Speaker, I so submit. Thank you.

1.0 Introduction

The Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025 was presented to Parliament by the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, in accordance with the 1992 Constitution and read for the first time on Wednesday, 9th July, 2025.

Subsequently, the Bill was referred to the Joint Committee Education and Public Administration and State Interest for consideration and report in accordance with the Standing Orders of Parliament.

2.0 Deliberations

The Joint Committee, in considering the Bill met with the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu; and officials from the Ministry of Justice and Attorney-General's Department, the Ministry of Education, and the Scholarship Secretariat.

3.0 Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents in the consideration of the Bill:

- i. The 1992 Constitution

- ii. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921)
- iii. The Standing Orders of Parliament

4.0 Object of the Bill

The object of the Bill is to establish the Ghana Scholarships Authority to regulate the administration and award of Government Scholarships in a transparent and equitable manner, and for related matters.

5.0 Contents of the Bill

The Bill contains Thirty-four (34) clauses.

Clause 1 establishes the Ghana Scholarships Authority. Clause 2 covers the objects of the Authority while Clause 3 is on the functions of the Authority.

Clause 4 deals with the Governing Body of the Authority. Clause 5 provides for the functions of the Board. Duties and liabilities of a member of the Board is captured in Clause 6.

Clause 7 deals with the tenure of office of members of the Board. Meetings of the Board is in Clause 8. Disclosure of interest is covered in Clause 9 while Clause 10 deals with establishment of committees. Clauses 11 and 12 are on Allowances and Policy Directives.

Clause 13 provides for the appointment of a Director-General. Clause 14 is on the functions of the

Director-General. Clause 15 makes provision for the appointment of a Deputy Director-General. Clause 16 states the functions of the Deputy Director-General.

The Secretary to the Board is provided for in Clause 17. Clause 18 deals with the appointment of other staff of the Authority. Clause 18 deals with the Internal Audit Unit.

Funds of the Authority is provided for in Clause 20. Bank Account and Expenses of the Authority is provided for in Clauses 21 and 22. Clause 23 is on Accounts and Audit while Clause 24 is on Annual Reports and other Reports.

Clause 25 is on the Eligibility Criteria for the award of scholarship. Clause 26 captures mode by which applications for scholarships are made. Clause 27 deals with the processes for considering applications for scholarships.

The mode for the award of scholarship is provided for in Clause 28 while the grounds for cancellation of scholarship is provided for in Clause 29.

Clause 30 makes provision for the Authority to collaborate with other relevant bodies. Clause 31 is on penalties for refusing to return to the country after completion of a programme of study, after benefiting from a scholarship.

Clause 32 is on Regulations. Clause 33 is on interpretations and Clause 34 deals with Transitional provisions

6.0 Observations and Recommendations

6.1 Rationale for the Bill

The Committee observed that over the years, the Scholarship Secretariat was faced with several challenges, making the Secretariat not able to practically carry out its functions. The Committee was informed that a major challenge was the absence of a legal framework to guide the operations of the Secretariat. Further, there were multiplicity of public institutions that handle and award scholarships without collaborating with the Secretariat. Also, the award of Government Scholarships have been plagued with political patronage, corruption, cronyism and nepotism. These challenges had adversely hampered the Secretariat's ability to fully and accurately report to Government and other stakeholders on all scholarships awarded by public institutions in the country.

Parliament has on a number of occasions discussed the need for a legal framework to guide the operations of the Secretariat. One of such parliamentary deliberations was captured in the Parliamentary Hansard, Fourth Series, Vol 97, No. 50 and dated Wednesday, 5th April, 2017 where the House discussed the need to introduce a Bill to regulate the administration of scholarships in the country.

As part of efforts to address the above challenges, the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill was presented to the House. It is expected that if passed, the

new law will address existing challenges by creating a new regime that streamlines the administration of Government Scholarships in a transparent and equitable manner, re-align and coordinate scholarships in the public sector and usher in a new era for the administration of Government scholarships.

6.2 Provision of scholarships in the country

The Committee observed that in order to ensure effective use of resources, the Bill provides for the award of foreign scholarships only when the said programmes were not available in the country including programmes for skills upgrade.

The Minister intimated that the policy shift was necessary to ensure that much more students benefit from the scholarship programmes. Further, it would also support the universities to enhance their reputation and competitiveness.

6.3 Award of scholarships

The Committee observed that some of the concerns of the citizenry were that the scholarships were not awarded based on merits and need-based.

The Minister assured the Committee that the new Bill had elaborate provisions to ensure that only deserving students who are Ghanaians and brilliant but needy would benefit from the support. Further, the Bill provided for the Authority to collaborate with relevant

stakeholders such as the West Africa Examination Council (WAEC), the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), and the Students Loan Trust Fund, among others, to identify deserving applicants for the award of the scholarships.

6.4 Focus on the study of Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) programmes

The Committee observed that the Bill provides that as part of its functions, the Authority was to determine disciplines that are critical to national development and award Government scholarships for the study in those disciplines with special focus on the study of STEM programmes.

The Minister indicated that STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) programmes offer numerous benefits, including, problem-solving skills, and career opportunities. They also foster creativity, innovation and equipping students with valuable skills applicable to various fields.

He said in view of the benefits to be derived from the STEM programmes, Government intends to support needy students who are willing to undertake these critical programmes in order to drive economic growth and improve Ghana's competitiveness in the global market.

6.5 Funding for the Authority

The Committee observed that a major challenge facing the Scholarship

Secretariat was funding and inquired how the Bill would address the issue.

The Minister informed the Committee that in addition to the other sources of funding, the Bill provides for up to two-percent of the total oil revenue and a percentage of moneys from the GETFund. It is expected that these would provide the needed financing for the Authority.

6.6 Award of Scholarships to Foreign Students

The Committee observed that pursuant to the Bill, only Ghanaians were qualified to apply for Government scholarships.

The Minister however indicated that scholarships are also a diplomatic tool for fostering and promoting international cooperation. He said many Ghanaians had benefited from such cooperation and therefore it was not in the interest of the country to ban foreigners from applying for the scholarships.

The Committee agreed with the Minister's opinion and called for a framework where under special instances, some foreign scholarships could be granted to foreigners.

6.7 Database for scholarship beneficiaries

The Committee observed that one of the challenges facing the present scholarship regime was the presence of multiplicity of public institutions handling and awarding scholarships

without collaboration with the Secretariat.

The Committee opined that in addition to the provision for relevant stakeholders to collaborate with the Authority, there is the need for a database of Government Scholarship beneficiaries to help eliminate instances where a beneficiary is awarded multiple bursaries.

The Ministry assured the Committee that such a database was already in place. However, steps would be taken to improve on it to make it much more efficient.

6.8 Timing from the release of scholarships funds to the Institutions

The Committee observed that a major challenge facing the beneficiaries of scholarships in the country is the payment of deposits to the tertiary institutions pending the release of the scholarship funds. The delay adversely affect the object of the award of the scholarships as the beneficiaries are unable to pay the deposit, hence they are dropped out from the institutions.

The Committee therefore recommended to the Ministry to relook at the award timelines to ensure that the release of the scholarships funds coincide with the payments of any fees to an institution so that beneficiaries benefit from the scholarship granted.

7.0 Recommendations

The Committee having carefully scrutinised the Bill proposes the

following amendments for the consideration of the House:

Amendments

1. **Clause 2 — Amendment proposed** — paragraph (d), *delete* and *insert* a new paragraph (d) as follows:

“(d) decentralise the award of Government scholarships.”.

2. **Clause 3 — Amendment proposed** — paragraph (i), line 2, at end, *add*

“including skills upgrading”.

3. **Clause 3 — Amendment proposed** — paragraph (j), *delete* and insert the following:

“(j) award scholarships to the first ten Ghanaian candidates adjudged by the West African Examination Council as the overall best candidates in the West Africa Senior School Certificate Examination;”

4. **Clause 3 — Amendment proposed** — paragraph (k), line 1, after “effective”, *insert* “and efficient”.

5. **Clause 4 — Amendment proposed** — Sub clause (1), paragraph (b), subparagraph (v), *delete* “Minister” and *insert* “Ministry”.

6. **Clause 4 — Amendment proposed** — Sub clause (1), after paragraph (d), insert a new paragraph (e) as follows:

“(e) one representative of the Student Loan Trust Fund not below the rank of a Director, nominated by the Governing body of Student Loan Trust Fund;”.

7. **Clause 17 — Amendment proposed** — Sub-clause (1), *delete* and *insert* a as follows:

“(1) The Director-General shall designate a staff of the Authority as Secretary to the Board.”

8. **Clause 20 — Amendment proposed** — paragraph (b), *delete* and *insert*

“(b) up to two percent of the total oil revenue”.

9. **Clause 20 — Amendment proposed** — paragraph (c), *delete* and *insert*

“(c) moneys approved by Parliament for scholarships in the Ghana Education Trust Fund”.

10. **Clause 25 — Amendment proposed** — *delete* and *insert* the following

25. (1) A person qualifies to apply for a scholarship under this Act if the person is

(a) Ghanaian; and

(b) brilliant but needy.

(2) Despite subsection (1), the Authority may, for the purpose of improving international cooperation, grant a scholarship to a person who is a non-Ghanaian.

(3) A scholarship awarded by the Authority shall be based on

(a) the merit of the applicant;

(b) the developmental need of the country; or

(c) the need to improve international cooperation.”

11. **Clause 27 — Amendment proposed** — *delete* and *insert* the following:

27. In assessing an application for scholarship under section 26, consideration shall be given to

(a) the academic excellence of the applicant;

(b) the financial need of the applicant;

- (c) the leadership and extra-curricular involvement by the applicant;
- (d) the special talent and skill of the applicant;
- (e) the field of study and career goal of the applicant;
- (f) a person with disability;
- (g) letter of recommendation for the applicant; and
- (h) the priorities of the donor institution.”.

12. Clause 28 — Amendment proposed — *delete and insert the following*

28. The Director-General shall, subject to the approval of the Board, award a scholarship under this Act.”.

13. Clause 31 — Amendment proposed — *delete and insert the following*

31. (1) A person who benefits from a scholarship under this Act to study outside the country shall, subject to the terms and conditions determined by the Authority, return to serve the country after completion of the programme of study.”

- (2) A person who contravenes subsection (1) shall pay to the Authority

- (a) a refund of the total amount of the scholarship awarded to the person: and
- (b) interest on the total amount of the scholarship at the prevailing Bank of Ghana rate.

- (3) Where a person fails to pay the penalty specified under subsection (2), the Authority shall recover the total amount of the scholarship and the applicable interest as a civil debt at a rate of twice the total amount of the scholarship and the interest on the total amount.

14. Clause 33 — Interpretation — Interpretation of “Government scholarship”, delete” and insert the following:

“Government scholarship” includes a bursary and a grant that is awarded by the Government, a public corporation, a bilateral partner or a multilateral partner;”

15. Clause 33 — Interpretation — after the definition for “district”, *add* a new definition as follows:

“Ghana Education Trust Fund” means the Ghana Education Trust Fund established under section 1 of the Ghana Education Trust Fund Act, 2000 (Act 581);”

16. Clause 33 — Interpretation —
add a new definition as follows:

“Student Loan Trust Fund” means the Student Loan Trust Fund established under the Student Loan Trust Act, 2011 (Act 820).”

8.0 Conclusion

After careful consideration, the Joint Committee is of the view that the Bill is in the right direction and therefore unanimously recommends to the House to adopt its Report and pass the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025 in accordance with the 1992 Constitution and the Standing Orders of the House.

Respectfully submitted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, pursuant to Standing Order 127, a full debate shall arise on the principles of the Bill on the basis of the Explanatory Memorandum and the Report of the Committee. The floor is now open.

Mr Mustapha Ussif (NPP — Yagaba-Kubori): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to comment on your Committee Report on the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025. Mr Speaker, your Committee met the Minister for Education, senior officials from the Ministry, and officials from the Scholarship Secretariat and Student Loan Trust Fund.

Mr Speaker, the Minister answered a series of questions posed by Members of your Committee and the Committee

made a series of observations on the Bill that was presented to the Committee.

Mr Speaker, the observations we made include that, once this House passes this Bill, the Act will streamline scholarship processes in Ghana. In that, going forward, once this Bill is passed, scholarship will be given to students to study abroad for only courses which are not offered in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the other observation we made has to do with funding. We observed that the major challenge for the Scholarship Secretariat has to do with funding, but the Minister answered the queries of the Committee that there are various other sources that, once this Bill is passed, will come into place, so that the challenge that we face, currently, with funding sources will be a thing of the past. And he mentioned that some about 2 per cent of the oil revenue, once the Bill is passed, will also be put into the fund of the Ghana Scholarships Authority.

The other sources will be loans and budgetary allocations that will also be passed by this House. Also, some portions of the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) formula, once this House passes the Bill, will be allocated to the funding sources of the Ghana Scholarships Authority. Mr Speaker, I want to urge this august House to support for us to pass this Bill, so that we can streamline the scholarship processes that we offer in this country.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Mr Speaker, I rise

to add my voice to the Motion before us and also ask that this House passes the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025 into law.

Mr Speaker, the policy objectives of this law is laudable. As it stands now, we have heard stories of our compatriots: our brothers and sisters outside this country, who are suffering and have not been remitted by Government, both in the past and in current terms.

Mr Speaker, this cannot continue because, as we know, it is only an institution under an umbrella of Government or the Executive or the Jubilee House, called Scholarship Secretariat. It is not an authority which this House will allocate funds into that authority.

7.55 p.m.

So, for the Minister to come with a Bill that will clarify and give authority to an institution where money would be allocated by this House into that singular authority will make it authoritative and prevent cronyism, where partisan consideration and friendship are considered before others are given scholarship.

When this is put together and people merit what it takes to have a scholarship, both within and outside, then we can hold the Authority responsible when things go wrong. As it stands now, who are we going to hold responsible for our brothers and sisters who are outside there who are suffering?

Mr Speaker, the objectives of this scholarship are also to give support to people who want to undertake courses that are not offered in this country. So, we will no longer be giving support to people who want to study courses that can be done in this country, so we can reduce our foreign exchange. But we will allow our brothers and sisters to go outside to pursue courses that are not pursued in this country.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I support this noble objective and ask that my Colleagues from both Sides of the House pass this into law.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Asante-Boateng?

Mr Kwaku Asante-Boateng (NPP — Asante Akim South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to add my voice in support of the Motion on the Floor.

Mr Speaker, looking at the Memorandum that accompanied the Bill, we realise that the Bill is very comprehensive. But that notwithstanding, there are a few gaps that I would like to draw the attention of the Minister and the House to. I made mention of that when we met, but same was not taken into consideration.

We realise that the essence of this Bill is to have a legal framework in order to help the Ghana Scholarship Secretariat operationalise its activities. But in so doing, Mr Speaker, the Secretariat is

supposed to collaborate with other scholarship-awarding institutions in the country, such that there will be proper coordination. But if we go through the respective clauses of the Bill, there is no mechanism put in place for such collaboration between the Scholarship Secretariat and the other awarding institutions.

Quite apart from that, we realise that they are supposed to streamline, for purposes of reporting, maybe on an annual or biannual basis. It depends on the Legislative Instrument that will accompany this. So, I just want to admonish the whole House to support it. But when it comes to the Consideration Stage, Hon Minister, I strongly believe that there is a need for us to look at those gaps that I have mentioned. So, that when we are looking at the legal framework for its entirety, the whole Bill will be holistic to cover all the areas.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I want to admonish both Sides of the House to support the passage of this Bill.

Thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Sosu, you have the floor.

Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC — Madina): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the Second Reading of the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, let me say that the essence of law is to cure mischiefs in society. And for the fact that the Minister for Education has seen that scholarship and scholarship-related matters are a problem and that there is a need for us to enact this law to resolve that problem, Mr Speaker, is a good cause that we all need to support. Mr Speaker, in the last four years, there have been many of us who have attempted to lead a constituent to assess scholarship from the Scholarship Secretariat. Mr Speaker, it would marvel you the kind of challenges people go through to assess scholarship from the Scholarship Secretariat.

Mr Speaker, it got to a time, at a very personal level, we realise that we have to, sometimes, even pay because if one cannot pay, they cannot get a scholarship. Mr Speaker, it became a source of business for some people. The only way we can resolve this matter so that moving forward, there will be certainty in the administration of scholarship, particularly for our brothers and sisters who are abroad, I believe, is the essence of this law.

Mr Speaker, as we speak now, as a Member of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, I know on authority that there are still a lot of students who are calling on the Ministry and people to intervene because they are abroad and they are not having funding. So, Mr Speaker, I call on this House to support this Bill, so that we can enact law to establish an authority that will have a dedicated fund to take care of our scholarship and streamline scholarship in

Ghana, so that we can resolve this very problem.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Asamoah?

8.05 p.m.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the passing of this Bill into an Act to support the way we give scholarships to our nationals. Scholarships could either be given to people based on need or excellence.

Mr Speaker, what this Bill is seeking to do is to strengthen meritocracy so that scholarships can be given based on merit, need and financial circumstances of Ghanaian students. This Bill will not only strengthen meritocracy but will also target national development. In focusing on Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) education, the Minister for Education explained that based on our national direction, this Authority will focus on giving scholarships, especially to those who will be going out of the country to embark on training that will come back to improve our economy.

In so doing, Mr Speaker, we will also have a well-financing source that will ensure the continuous implementation of our scholarship system. It is quite unfortunate that some students might be locked up out of the country and we might not have continuous funds to take

care of them. So, for me, if we have an Act and an Authority that will ensure that our students are taken care of wherever they are, we will not be worried and we will not be finding ourselves wanting on whether these students can continue their education.

Mr Speaker, one of the things that was a bit of a concern to the Committee was the funding source or the percentage of our oil revenue that will be focused on this scholarship system. We believe that this House will make a decisive decision to ensure that there is a continuous stream of funding to the Authority for its functioning.

Mr Speaker, then also, one other thing is that we believe this Act is a start because we realised that our scholarship system within other agencies of the Government is also taking funding from the Consolidated Fund.

And we believe that, in as much as it will be very difficult as a start to realign all Government scholarship, and the emphasis is on Government scholarship, which is coming from the Consolidated Fund or public funds, it should be properly realigned so that we do not have people double-dipping. And as such, the Committee encourages that during the implementation there should be a central system that will allow us to track each one of us that is benefiting from this scholarship system.

Mr Speaker, with these few words I would like to support the passing of this Bill into an Act so that we can properly establish a Scholarship Authority.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Ampofo?

Mr Kwame Twumasi Ampofo (NDC — Sene West): Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I think this Bill is very important in this nation. This scholarship has helped a lot of people. It has also affected a lot of people in this country, especially those outside. When one is outside the country and knows that they have been awarded a scholarship and at the end of the day the money is not coming, it makes it difficult for one to survive. That is the only hope they have; so, that is a very disadvantaged part of the scholarship scheme.

Mr Speaker, I think anytime we are awarding any scholarship to somebody, we must make sure that we will be able to fulfil the promise because it has frustrated a lot of people. Therefore, it is good to come up with this Bill to assist our children, our wards and our people outside the country. There are a lot of cries that we have heard for so many years that they are not paying. So, I think with this collaboration, if we are able to govern it well, it will help all of us because some people are so poor but are very good academically and they do not have support. So, if they have this scholarship, it helps them to go far.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I think it is very good for us to come up with this Bill so that they become an Authority and then they can collaborate with the Minister and other institutions that are governed with a scholarship to

help our own children to do their best as they can so that they will not be frustrated.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam/Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, I rise to speak in line with Order 167 and let me start off by commending the Leadership of the two Committees and the Minister.

Mr Speaker, permit me to walk you through the advocacy for this piece of legislation and *Hansard* will bear me out. Mr Speaker, I first made a Statement and called for this law in 2014. Anybody can check the *Hansard*. Then, in 2017, I repeated the call and it is gratifying to announce, and here I am not being political, that the NPP administration tried a form of decentralisation. How was it done? The applications to the Scholarship Secretariat were received at the District and Municipal level. So, the assessments were done at the District and Municipal level and then those who were shortlisted were ferried to the Scholarship Secretariat.

I concede, however, that this is the first time we are trying a full-blown Authority to be established for the disbursement of scholarship. Mr Speaker, the need for this body cannot be overemphasised and I think back and forth we have shown regret and lamented about the whole matter because the Scholarship Secretariat was established, as we are

told, in the 1960s. In 1960, it was established and it was tied to the apron strings of the Presidency and it has been like that to this day. That is why I want to doff my cap to the Minister who has shown leadership, not just the timeous intervention, but if you look at the intendment; equitable award of scholarship, making sure that it becomes one-stop shop.

Because we are aware the Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and other parastatal bodies who offer scholarships get funds, and they do it on their own understanding and merit. This is the first time we are going to do a thing like this and I know that Hon Haruna Iddrisu's name will go into the history to have shepherded it, have led it and it is very impressive.

We must also be clear in our minds, and I see that oftentimes, we rehash this statement, science and mathematics: the focus will look at science and mathematics and STEM education and all that. We are often overly focused on that narrative, but we have a creature in this country called the National Development Planning Commission (NDPC) and we have left it in a dormant state.

How can we leverage on the—If you go to the National Development Planning Commission, they have a number of suggestions, that is, the area of academic work, our infrastructure needs and all that. I want to plead with the Minister and this House, that we must find a way to draw a certain relationship between our academic pursuits and the

fees that come from the National Development Planning Commission. It is so important.

Mr Speaker, a while ago we heard about Ghanaian students abroad, all over the news who do not have funding. The irony of the matter is that it is the same scholarship offering body that has granted them the green lights to go ahead and study and yet payments of bursaries and support come lacking. It is not peculiar to this administration; I am being fair here. In the NPP time it happened, even though I think theirs looks too bad, but in the NPP time too, it happened.

So, what is the solution? The solution is to get an Authority that will be able to supervise and ensure we do away with the partisan approach in all these matters. I hope it will not just be one of the creatures. We create it and then when we have to give it the necessary oxygen to prosecute on its public function, then we come lacking.

Mr Speaker, I am concluding on this note, what are we going to do about the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund)? We know GETFund and all the other institutions also offer scholarship. We have to draw on their functionality and get this thing structured so well that we will not be found wanting.

Mr Speaker, I would not want to belabour the point. My heart is at rest. I am excited because the last time in 2014, when I visited the Scholarship Secretariat, a child from Wirenkyiren

Amanfrom, far away in my Constituency, together with the parents, had come to spend three nights at the Scholarship Secretariat and that was what motivated me to present the Statement. I recall the respected Doe Adjaho was then the Speaker of Parliament and unfortunately, we could not take a definite decision on this.

Today, this Parliament is making history for the fact that from 1960, we never thought about blazing the trail. Today, we are doing it. We need to pat ourselves on the shoulder and make sure we do it and do it well for the benefit of future generations and even present generations.

Mr Speaker, I thank you and I commend the Minister once more. I am grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Yes, Minority Leader?

8.15 p.m.

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu): Mr Speaker, just to continue from where my respected Colleague, the Chief Whip, ended.

Mr Speaker, I have gone through the Reports of the Joint Committee that received the referral and let me first commend them for their industry and their hard work. They make some few observations and it is appropriate to re-echo these observations.

Mr Speaker, at page 7, paragraph number 6.6, this is what the Report says:

“The Committee observed that pursuant to the Bill, only Ghanaians were qualified to apply for Government scholarships. The Minister, however, indicated that scholarships are also a diplomatic tool for fostering and promoting international cooperation...”

He said:

“Many Ghanaians had benefited from such cooperation, and therefore it was not in the interest of the country to ban foreigners from applying for scholarships. The Committee agreed with the Minister’s opinion and called for a framework where, under special instances, some foreign scholarship could be granted to foreigners”.

Mr Speaker, this is where I have a problem. Which of the clauses is going to deal with it, and under what circumstance? It should be properly laid out, and as we go into the enactment proper, this must be addressed.

Mr Speaker, if we are having a Scholarship Authority that would look at the peculiar needs of our people, that should be so. If at the diplomatic level there is some other arrangement, that could be catered for. But to say that we would have this Authority grant scholarships to foreign applicants, that, Mr Speaker, the Minister would have to look at the basis for introducing that in this Bill. I strongly hold the view that it

is very inappropriate to enact on this. It does not send a good signal.

Those other advanced countries that are awarding scholarships to developing countries, they have enough. Are we saying that this is going to be open to West Africans, or what? We should be very clear, and in order to avoid ambiguity, I would suggest that we stay our hands off this for now.

Mr Speaker, at paragraph 6.4, the Committee makes a strong case for emphasis to be placed on Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) programmes. We do not often compliment those who lead the charge to bring transformation in this country, but—I think Hon Aduwum, who is a Ranking Member on Education, is not here—but even in his absence, whatever solid foundation is laid, let us commend him for his hard work, as well as his predecessor, Dr Matthew Opoku-Prempeh, for all the work they did together.

I am happy, with the little I know about Hon Haruna Iddrisu, Mr Speaker, I am not singling him out for praise, but it is important—His appreciation of governance, I would not say is second to none, but it is commendable.

He has a clear appreciation of governance, and how we must ensure continuity, how we must encourage views from our respective political parties to be properly laid for the purpose of national development. That must not be taken away from him.

Mr Speaker, I am therefore happy that his emphasis is on STEM programmes, because countries like Germany are doing well because of their emphasis on STEM. Most of our children are very skilled, but it appears we are not giving them attention. The last eight years have seen a lot of infrastructure development in our various Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) institutions. We have seen tools being provided. We have even seen that Government introduced free tuition for TVET.

Originally, the TVET or our Technical Institutions were not part of the free SHS. They are now part of it and we are saying that for this Scholarships Authority, we are going to encourage more and more of our young ones to go into that area of skill training.

Mr Speaker, after all the issues about vigilantism and all our people being unemployed, getting involved in *galamsey*, destroying our environment, is as a result of lack of skills and they do not have anybody to provide them that basic training.

As Members of Parliament, we know. In our various constituencies, the call is on us to provide support for skilled training. So, if this authority is going to provide support by way of scholarship to our young ones in that area, I again commend that effort.

Mr Speaker, I come to paragraph 6.5. For any initiative like this, we need dedicated funding and I am happy reading in paragraph 6.5 that there is a 2

per cent of total oil revenue being allocated for this.

Mr Speaker, I do not know whether the Cabinet has already approved it and if that has been done, I would even advocate for more. When we get to the Consideration Stage, we can propose an amendment to increase this to 4 per cent or more.

Mr Speaker, so it is a good call that if Government is investing in social interventions, this is one key area that we can invest more and we will be rest assured that if our young ones are trained and acquire skills, it benefits the country.

Mr Speaker, that said, let me come to the issue of the choice of programmes to benefit from this. Mr Speaker, if only this Authority would be very strict, it will save us a lot. Sometimes we do not want to say it, but it is true. Those who assist us into coming into this Chamber, now that NDC is in power, we will see more of the TEIN members walking to the offices of the Minister that they want scholarship and they mobilised on campus. It is the same thing that happened to us.

Mr Speaker, I have a lot of applications from TESCON executives; vice president, financial secretary and sometimes they come with programmes that can be offered right here but they want to go abroad and one has to look for money or take them to Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund). So, it is good we are sanitising. This is one of the things I called for some few days ago. That as a Parliament, let us have a national

conversation on some critical areas because in the long term, it is going to benefit governance and democracy and I am happy the leader of Government Business will have his bite after me. He is leading us. He can identify some key areas of governance for us to begin deliberating on them, and have consensus on it, and invite the Executive to take these on board.

8.25p.m.

Mr Speaker, if we are able to build consensus on key national issues as politicians, we would be able to manage our governance structure in such a way that all of us would understand that one day, we will come to power and we will need this. But if we go partisan on everything, like the way, just six months—I am not being partisan here, but I am telling them the truth. Trade Union Congress (TUC), through its research, is telling Ghanaians that, within six months, *galamsey* is getting out of hand. Maybe, because they are in government, they may not admit it, but it is a serious matter.

Mr Speaker, when we go to the energy sector; we have a lot of leakages. These are matters that we can build a consensus on that these are no-go areas for partisan comment because when the environment is being destroyed, it is the country that is going down. If all our moneys are going to pay energy bills and there is leakage there and we are supposed to impose levies or taxes—But if we have a national consensus and both sides are speaking the same language and there is

an attitudinal change, our country will be better. And I say this in all sincerity.

So, Mr Speaker, I am happy that this Bill is only looking at, especially, courses abroad that we cannot find here as the only courses that scholarship may be awarded for or under very exceptional circumstances that the person may have to go out of the country and be given scholarship to be trained. If we would go by it and not allow our party people to blackmail us or because we want to do a favour, we now turn a blind eye and then do all of that, Mr Speaker, it is going to help.

We know what is happening in University of Memphis, Tennessee. Our Colleague, Dr Kyei Asamoah, recently brought this matter up where 181 of our Ghanaian scholarship beneficiaries in this university are stranded because— There are even more. Mr Speaker, the Deputy Minister for Education even said that the numbers here are being understated; there are over 500 stranded in the United Kingdom (UK). Mr Speaker, more of them are stranded and we have to look for the money. But these courses can be offered here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, kindly wind up.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, so, with what is happening, we should now take the bull by the horn and use this enactment to cure the problems that we have created as political leaders. We should take this opportunity to cure.

So, Mr Speaker, having taken a cue from you, most respectfully, I will end my submission by assuring the Hon Minister and the Government that we, on this Side of the House, will participate fully in this enactment. Our prayer is that the amendment that will come from us be accommodated. It is all for the good of the country. We want this new law and the Authority to stand the test of time and that we should also not rush it.

Mr Speaker, we respect the Hon Minister and we would support him. Let us take our time and deal with this Bill, so that, tomorrow, he will be proud that his Colleagues assisted him to enact a law that posterity will judge his records by.

Mr Speaker, that said, let me thank you for indulging me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Thank you very much Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me join my Colleagues to commend the Minister for presenting this Bill to the House for passage into law.

Mr Speaker, this is one of the promises made by the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in our manifesto and we gave timelines to have this enacted by this Parliament and the Minister has expeditiously brought this Bill before us, clearly within those timelines, so that we can meet the targeted timelines that we have committed ourselves to. So, let me

commend the Minister for acting with dispatch to bring this Bill.

Mr Speaker, this is a government that has committed to reset this country—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Mr Speaker, the public scholarship of this country has, for far too long, been plagued by political patronage. That is a fact. It has been plagued by corruption, cronyism, and nepotism. Scholarships have largely been given to the undeserving and the only reason many of those people got the scholarships was because they knew one politician or the other and not because they deserved those scholarships. Not even because they needed the scholarships.

Mr Speaker, this level of cronyism and corruption has, indeed, destroyed our body politic and that is what has necessitated the NDC, as a party, taking a decision to streamline the process and establish an Authority, with the hope that that authority will function in a way that takes out cronyism, corruption, nepotism, and all the negative tendencies that have plagued the awards of scholarships in this country. So, I am happy that we are making an attempt and I hope that this House will help, during Consideration Stage, to fashion a legislation that will address these major challenges.

Mr Speaker, I have looked at the objects and I support the objects of the Bill, except to add that, once again, this country has been very wasteful. Wasteful in the sense that we have largely promised to be efficient, but in the end, we send children out to go and study

what they could actually learn back here at home. And we give moneys to foreign universities when our own local universities are crying for the same resources, sometimes, even less, so that they could also be world-class universities.

But we deny them those resources and we export the children to other countries and we send them money. Those moneys go to fund other economies and perfect the educational systems of other countries, so when we say we are passing a legislation to regulate it, let us have a legislation that cures this particular ill.

So, I see, in the objects of the Bill, a provision that scholarship will not be awarded to any person to study outside, unless that course is not offered by any university in Ghana. And I hope that this House will tighten those provisions, so that they will never be abused and curtail the waste, the export of scarce resources, and the denial of our own domestic universities of resources that they need to also perfect their acts.

Mr Speaker, I have looked at the structure of the Bill, the creation of the Board and the composition of the Board. When we say that a fundamental criterion for determining who will enjoy scholarship is “needs” and we set up a Board and have several Ministries, but leave out the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, how are we going to perfect the act of needs assessment when we leave out the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection in the composition of the Board?

8.35 p.m.

I will urge that during the Consideration Stage, we consider seriously including the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, so that we will have the people from the Ministry sitting on the board to try and enforce our commitments to gender balance when allocating these scholarships.

So that we can have the Ministry responsible for Social Protection on the board to help the Scholarship Secretariat develop effective mechanisms for needs assessment. Also, so that we can target the right kind of people.

That in the end, we do not have a scholarship board that is busy pandering to the needs of politicians, and addressing the needs of rich people, political elites, technocrats and senior civil servants who want to ship their children out to benefit from international studies, while the sons and daughters of the poor are actually left out. I think that we should look at that.

Mr Speaker, I have also looked at the board, the functions of the board and the award of scholarships as a function of the board. When I look at the composition of the board, when we say that these Ministries should present representatives not below the rank of director, there are people above the rank of director or at the level of directors who really have nothing to do with scholarships or the

competencies needed to take decisions regarding the award of scholarships.

When we compose a board of those characteristics and give them the power to award scholarships, we may end up with a situation where they will not be the right people to take decisions about what kind of areas scholarships should go to or what kind of individuals should actually be awarded the scholarships, so let us consider that.

Yes, we need a board to provide leadership in terms of the management and supervision of the activities of the authority, but can we consider having a scholarship committee, that is not necessarily the board members who are—*[Interruption]*—No, if we look at the functions, the decision is largely that of the board. Are you getting the situation? The decision is largely that of the board. If we go to academic institutions like the universities, they all have scholarships, but they make sure that it is a specialised committee that really is the decision-making body in the determination of who gets scholarships, so we may have to think closely at that.

Mr Speaker, with these few observations, I join Colleagues to commend the Minister highly for expeditiously bringing this Bill and putting together this Bill within the constraints of the few months in office, so that this House can help fashion out a very good legislation on scholarships to deal with the ills that have plagued the award of scholarships in the country for the past six or seven decades.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025 accordingly read a Second time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Hon Majority Leader has just signalled that we should start the consideration which we are not opposed to. However, I want to passionately appeal—Everybody who spoke to this Business spoke with a certain passion.

We should not be in a hurry. Let us be careful and consider the clauses. This is a very sensitive matter and it is not for nothing that it has been at the apron strings of the Presidency since 1960. Let us create this creature well. We should not be in a hurry to pass it today. Let us take our time and do the work well and where people have issues at the consideration, we should consider it and get it done well.

Mr Speaker, this is my humble appeal through the Majority leader to the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, if that is the sense of the House, Minister for Education, you may move the Motion numbered 16.

MOTION

Suspension of Standing Order 169(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Order 169(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a Bill has been read a Second time, the Bill shall pass through a Consideration Stage, which shall not be taken until at least two sitting days have elapsed, the Consideration Stage of the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025 may be *taken* today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Motion is accordingly moved; any seconder?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025

Clause 1 - Establishment of the Ghana Scholarships Authority

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is no advertised amendment from the Committee. It is, however, for the consideration of the House.

Mr John Darko: Mr Speaker, with respect, for guidance, I strongly believe that the arrangement of sections should be changed, but I do not know whether that can be done now or when everything is completed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you can propose it, so clause 1.

Mr Darko: All right, but then it is not clause 1; it is clause 9, so when we get there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Your issue is with clause 9?

Mr Darko: Yes, so the numbering, I thought that we need to change—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it the numbering of clause 1?

Mr Darko: No, it is for clause 9, so when we get there, then I will propose it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, in the absence of any proposed amendment to clause 1—Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Kwabena Boateng: Mr Speaker, respectfully, clause 1(3) reads:

“Where there is a hindrance to the acquisition of land, the land may be acquired for the Authority under the

Land Act, 2020 (Act 1036) and the cost shall be borne by the Authority.”

Mr Speaker, may I get clearance if what is in the contemplation of the sponsors of the Bill is compulsory acquisition or any other mode of acquisition? Mr Speaker, if what we are contemplating is compulsory acquisition, may we be very clear, since we have other modes of acquisition of land in Act 1036?

8.45 p.m.

Mr Nortsu Kotoe: Mr Speaker, that has been the format over the time, and it has become a template for all the Bills that we have taken so far.

Thank you.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, I side with the enquiry raised by my Colleague to the extent that when it comes to the establishment of a Scholarship Authority and looking at the object, the functions and the mandate of the Authority, it is really a difficulty in determining under what conditions we want to impose a compulsory acquisition of land under the Land Act, 2020 (Act 1036). It is unlike the establishment of other government agencies that require land for other purposes.

So, again, it is not a matter of this House following routine formalities, but it is whether the clause is necessarily needed for the purposes of the Scholarship Secretariat. I think that we

should have a second look at it, and I would have also made a proposal to amend that particular clause.

Mr Shaibu Mahama: Mr Speaker, I do not think that we should belabour this point. As found in clause 1, subclause (2), land is part of the property that is contemplated for acquisition if the Authority so wishes. But there are instances where, because it is a state institution, some acquisitions may be such that you will need the state to use the Lands Commission Act, 1994 (Act 483) to be able to do the acquisition.

And so, we have set out this as a measure to say that where the institution wants to acquire property and there is a hindrance. In fact, we could have left subclause (3) out and it would have still been covered under subclause (2). But there are instances where there is a particular area that you want to cite something that is of interest to the State and to the Authority.

And that is where compulsory acquisition comes in. And that is where the hindrance explains where we are now. And so, we have used this over time. It is a template that we have adopted and it is accepted in all the legislations that we have used here.

I will pray that my Colleagues abandon this so we make progress on this.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Kwabena Boateng: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I agree with my brother to

an extent. The problem is not whether the institution should acquire land or not. My problem is that if we say in a situation of hindrance, land may be acquired for the institution. If what we are contemplating is compulsory acquisition, we should say so because you will see that Section 233 of Act 1036 will talk about compulsory acquisition.

But if you go to Section 234, it talks about other modes, which is purchase. The state may directly purchase without compulsory acquisition. It even talks about gift, where somebody may, out of magnanimity, also gift a parcel of land to the state. So, which one is within our contemplation, if we can be specific?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the law is making reference to the Land Act. Once the law is making reference to the Land Act, where there is hindrance, whatever mode of acquisition that is applicable under the Land Act would then be adopted. Now, if you are asking that we should be specific, what if it is other modes contemplated by the Land Act that is applicable? So, you have answered your own question by quoting the relevant sections in the Land Act to say that the Land Act does not contemplate only a compulsory acquisition. That is why a blanket reference is being made to the Land Act.

Mr Boateng: Mr Speaker, I yield.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So your concern, do you also yield?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Rightly so, Mr Speaker.

Clause 1 ordered to stand as part of the bill.

Clause 2 — Objects of the Authority.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 2, subclause (d), *delete* “to the districts” for it to read, “decentralise the award of government scholarships”.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am trying to follow the Chairman. The rendition as he read is still not clear. If he says “decentralise”, what does he mean? To what extent?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, if you go further to clause 3, you will find what you have just deleted “to the districts”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you talking with specific reference to clause 3, subclause (k)?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Yes, please, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, should I put a question on the proposed amendment of the Chairman of the Committee to clause 2, subclause (d)?

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 2 as amended ordered to stand as part of the Bill.

Clause 3 — Functions of the Authority.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 3, paragraph (i), line 2, at end, *insert* “including skills upgrading” to read, “award foreign scholarships for only programmes that are not available in the country, including skills upgrading”.

8.55 p.m.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, my concern in this proposed amendment has to do clearly with the limitation of awarding foreign scholarships to only programmes that are not available in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, my difficulty stems from the fact that inasmuch as we want to promote scholarship for the purposes of courses that are not mainly done in this country,

By this Act limiting the right to award scholarship to students to foreign jurisdictions with necessarily a programme that is also being held in Ghana, I think that is a big challenge. So, I am of the respectful view that we should be able to allow students to benefit from scholarships in other courses, though we have some in Ghana, but rather limit the extent of those scholarships.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it has been indicated that we need to have the way of carrying the fresh Members of Parliament. With all due respect, some principles have to be debated at the Second Reading of a Bill and I believe strongly this was one of the

principles that was debated at the Second Reading of the Bill.

Now, when you get to Consideration Stage, you do not behave as if you are debating the principle based on which the Bill was brought. So, what you have just done will constitute a debate of the principle, a stage that we have passed. So, you recall that during the Second Reading of the Bill, this particular issue that you are raising has been debated, so if you are not convinced, then when you get to the clause, you propose an amendment. At Consideration Stage, that is what we are expected to do. If you have a proposed amendment to the clause, then you can go ahead and make your proposed amendment for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Hon Jerry Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I have a proposed amendment for 3(h).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the Rule is that if there is a proposed amendment under consideration, it must be voted on by the House before we can move to another clause. So, the Chairman has proposed an amendment that at the end of line 2, after country, *insert* “including skills upgrading”. That is for the consideration of the House.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Yes, any further amendment? Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Yes, Mr Speaker. Under clause 3(h), I want to propose the deletion of “details of the applicant for”. It reads that: “ensure the publication of details of the applicants for and the beneficiaries of...”. I want to propose the deletion of “the applicant for” and then leave it at “the beneficiaries of Government scholarships...”.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, the proposed amendment is for your consideration. In (h), the proposal is to *delete* “the applicant for” and then the rendition will be:

“ensure publication of the details of the beneficiaries of Government scholarships before and after the award of the Government scholarship”.

It is for the consideration of the House. Hon Members, I intend to put a Question on the proposed amendment by the Hon member.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Any further proposed amendment?

Hon Members, with all due respect, we are at the Consideration Stage of the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025. So, can we remain silent and take part in the process?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I still want to seek your guidance. This is still in

reference to 3(h). I was thinking that the rendition could be that:

“ensure the publication of details of the beneficiaries of Government scholarships both before and immediately after the award of Government scholarships”.

Mr Speaker, I do not know if you want me to go over.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I get the sense. You want the publication to be immediately after the award of the scholarship. But the rendition is before and after the award of the scholarship. Why do you say immediately?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are dealing with time. Even with the guidance of the Leader, we want to prevent a lot of things, including cronyism, nepotism, even corruption and basically, with reference to transparency.

The moment it is done after, just immediately, one will not have the room to operate in a manner that they will not be able to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Hon Mahama Shaibu?

Mr Mahama Shaibu: Mr Speaker, on a second thought, I think that the amendment we carried should have remained. For purposes of transparency, we want to know those who applied and out of the applicants, those who are beneficiaries and so, the publication should have the applicants and then those who have been successful so that we

have the true database that would inform future consideration. So that if an applicant is not successful for the first time, the name of the person would be on the database and maybe up for consideration in the next—I think that we should leave the rendition as it stands.

9.05 p.m

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Even the amendment that we have carried, we have to take a second look at it because “ensure the publication of details of the applicants...”, that is, details of everybody who applied must be published. Then with the second aspect,

“...the beneficiaries of the Government scholarship before and after the award of the Government scholarship;”

It is not every applicant that will be a beneficiary. So, if you delete details of the applicants, then it means the publication that they are talking about would exclude some applicants who are not beneficiaries.

Yes, Hon Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I agree with you that we should include applicants to indicate the numbers that actually applied and to also know those who actually benefited. For the purposes of accountability and transparency.

Mr Speaker, but my further request is that it should not be before and after. It should be before and immediately.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, as for your “immediately” that you are proposing, the question, therefore is, who determines? Also, the scholarships will not all be awarded in a day, so it depends on the calendar of the beneficiary schools. So, when you say “immediately”, does it mean, if immediately the person is awarded the scholarship, then the publication is made in respect of that beneficiary only? Then, there will be several publications.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, it is immediately after the award of the scholarship and by that “immediately” means, in my understanding, within the period of those awards.

So, if every year—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It will bring some element of subjectivity into reading the law. So, should I take it that “immediate” means one month and somebody said “immediate” means one day or one week. So, we need to avoid that kind of ambiguity.

But, let me hear you, Hon Kyei, because we did not put a question on the entire clause 3. We are revisiting the 3(h).

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, with the amendment that was proposed for (h), where we are to delete “the details of applicants”, I would suggest that, because we can have like 200,000 applicants applying but, maybe, 1,000 applicants might be successful and become beneficiaries, we would not want to publish the entire 200,000

applicants. So, we can— But because we are supposed to keep a database of the applicants in order not to take away the details of the applicants who applied for verification purposes and further studies, I would ask that we introduce another sentence that will deal with the Board having to keep a database of applicants, so that we can have one other clause that will take care of that particular detail. So, we do not take it out completely.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Chairman of the Committee, if we are talking about publication, is it publication in the *Gazette*, the website or newspaper of national circulation?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, it will be on the website of the Authority.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then, that one must be indicated in the law that:

“ensure publication of the details of the applicants at the website of the Scholarship Authority”.

Then, let it come as a closing phrase.

Yes, Hon Member, do you want to provide a rendition?

Dr Mahama: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I am proposing an amendment to clause 3(h) and the new rendition will read:

“ensure the publication on the website of the Authority the details of the applicants for and the beneficiaries of Ghana Scholarships before and after

the award of a government scholarship.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is a very good rendition.

So, Hon Members—

Yes, Hon Kyei?

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I think I want to keep the earlier rendition if we want to include the publication on the website of the Authority. But, as far as the applicants are concerned, that is what I am proposing—Because that one can be for data reviews. I am proposing we take the “applicants” out of (h). The details of the applicants should be taken and put in a different clause while we keep the beneficiaries. So, I would like to put it on the same clause (h).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, are you opposed to his amendment?

Dr Asamoah: Yes, to the extent that we should take out the details of the applicants, then we can create another one that will deal with keeping the database of the applicants.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Kyei, if the information is stored in a database, how would the public be able to check for corruption and ensure transparency? Because it must be on database of the Authority for the public to know the people who applied, but, on a political line, you sidelined these people and you awarded it to these people. That is the very essence. That is what I am gathering from here.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, and much more so because when we delete the publication of applicants from the clause, we, basically, do not allow people to know the people who applied and those who were selected thereafter.

Again, I am equally aware that the Data Protection Act, 2012 (Act 843) protects the kind of information of applicants that can be shared on the website. So, that mischief that, probably, my Colleague wants to cure is already regulated by law that certain information of an applicant cannot be put out there. But those that are relevant to the application and for the purpose of knowing who applied would have to be published for the purpose of transparency, Mr Speaker.

So, the proposed amendment as so moved, I pray that we carry it as such.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Adams?

Mr Adams: I want to suggest that if the rendition of Hon Kabiru is to stay, then we should, probably, add “and other relevant media”. Because if we stick to only the website and tomorrow the—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Adams, I am not cutting you short, but he is talking about the volume. And have you imagined the cost that would be involved in making that particular publication in other media?

Mr Adam: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I think the concerns that I had, in terms of publishing the details of the applicant, was in respect of volume and other considerations. But with this new rendition whereby—Of course, it is a matter of transparency that portions of these details can be published on the official website of the institution. And it also makes the same allowance for database of the information we are talking about. So, we should be able to consider the proposal made by Hon Kabiru and then we proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon members, I intend—

Yes, Hon Anyimadu?

9.15 p.m.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I have been considering whether we need to consider any of these amendments. I think “publication” is publication, whether it is on the website or wherever, it is publication. Besides that, if we look at clause 32, the Minister has the right to come out with Regulations. So, these details can be captured in the Regulations, whether it must be on a website or whatnot, then it could be in a newspaper, on the website and whatnot. But as it is captured here for the substantive law, I think that is alright.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, your view is that we do not even need any proposed amendment to clause 3(h)?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: That is so, Mr Speaker.

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, I support the argument that the clause should stand as it is. In a situation where somebody did not apply and becomes a beneficiary, how would we know if there is no such publication? Because we live in a country like that, where, maybe, somebody did not apply for that scholarship, but could be a beneficiary—*[Interruption]*—Yes, it will come, but this one is to put the information in the public domain, so that we know those who applied and those who did not. So, it should stand as it is.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am sorry. I think Hon Anyimadu-Antwi has made our work easy. When we refer to clause 32, even though it gives a prior indication of the areas that could be captured in a Regulation by the Minister in consultation with the Board. Clause 32(d) says:

“any other matter necessary for the effective and efficient implementation of this Act.”

So, I think we should leave it as it is.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I am convinced. This is because if you look at clause 32(a), it reads:

“The Minister may, in consultation with the Board, by legislative instrument, make Regulations to provide for

- (a) the procedure for application for a Government scholarship,
- (b) eligibility criteria for a Government scholarship;
- (c) the skills needed for the development of the country for which a Government scholarship should be awarded; and
- (d) any other matter necessary for effective and efficient implementation of this Act.”

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, we are guided. This whole confusion came about because of the question you asked on the publication in the *gazette*, but to the extent that we contemplate that it would be provided for under the Regulation, I think that the current rendition should stand as proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, by consensus of the House, the provision in clause 3(h) is ordered to stand as it is. Then I will put the Question on the entire clause 3.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move that clause 3, paragraph (j), *delete* and *insert* the following:

“award scholarships for the first ten Ghanaian candidates adjudged by the West African Examination Council as the overall best candidates in the West Africa Senior School Certificate Examination;”

Mr Speaker, this proposal is based on the recent awards organised by the West

African Examinations Council (WAEC) where some students were awarded for excellent or meritorious performance. There was one candidate who topped in Visual Arts. All others had admission to the universities to do their degree courses, but because his parents could not afford, he is now reading a certificate course in the Western Region. So, we feel that there should be a provision for merit award, so that where we have such situations, the Scholarships Authority can take care of their needs as a form of award.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Chairman of the Committee, if my ward happens to be among the best 10 West African students and has an admission at the University of Ghana, though I can afford to make every payment, automatically, my ward will be awarded a scholarship. Now, the second reason is that we have given the opportunity to the board to determine the criteria and terms for the award of the government scholarships.

Do you not think that this will be a function exercised by the board of the committee, so that among the best 10 students, the board will actually put a criteria to determine the deserving student for the scholarship? However, I will open the floor for it to be debated.

Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Kabiru Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that the operationalisation of that particular idea and the problem that idea seeks to solve can be done through the board. Another example is that some of

these best students get other scholarships, sometimes scholarships outside of the country. But if we legislate it and make it compulsory for them to benefit, it basically makes it a law that irrespective of the scholarship that the person is enjoying, the Ghana Scholarships Secretariat should provide them with a scholarship. I think that we can allow that to be run by the board, rather than letting it be part of the functions of the board so to speak.

9.25 p.m.

Mr Shaibu Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that I just prevailed on the Chairman to abandon that amendment because clause 32(b) has made sufficient provision if there is a need to create a special scholarship. Clause 32(b) states:

“(32) The Minister may, in consultation with the Board, by legislative instrument, make Regulations to provide for

(b) eligibility criteria for a Government scholarship;”

So, once we are making regulations, we can include the government scholarships and the rest of that. I think this is cured.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, it was when I appeared before the Committee and after an event I attended with the Chairman at the West African Examinations Council that I made this appeal. And, Colleagues, to persuade you, even though Mr Speaker gave an example of himself and his child,

scholarship, as it pertains everywhere in the world, can reward brilliance, need and international exchange. Mr Speaker, when those young boys and girls are shown to the country as the country's best in the West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE) and that the state is honouring them, we are encouraging their colleagues to study very hard.

So, there is a reason behind it; this is not ordinary. In fact, Mr Speaker, in some countries now, even the best students across the country are put in a special school of excellence because they are their best brains. My encouragement of this to the Committee was the fact that even though this award is by the President, it is not determined by him.

It is WAEC that would conduct this examinations, declare both in West Africa and in Ghana, the best students and normally, Mr Speaker, all of them will get eight As. We need to encourage and inspire these young people that they must look up to the award winners so that those following will be encouraged to study hard. But if you think that eligibility can define it—I just thought that you must have a room where every year, when WAEC—in fact, Mr Speaker, in the WAEC calendar every year, they undertake this award. So when they finish the award, then we will recommend to the President that all these students must qualify for the State's support. But if there is an objection, I will not insist on it.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so the sense of the House is that, Hon Minister, once you are coming back to the House—In consultation with the Board, bring a regulation, which regulation will determine the eligibility criteria. If the eligibility criteria is for one to qualify for the scholarship, the person must be part of the top 20 students, that is the eligibility criteria and nobody will have a problem about it. It is rather than determining the eligibility criteria in the law and the regulation will again determine the eligibility criteria.

So Chairman of the Committee, what do you say?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, we can abandon it but the subclause (j) will still be deleted because we have taken care of it in subclause (i) already.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes?

Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I am not happy that the Chairman is abandoning this amendment. Mr Speaker, in as much as I appreciate where you are coming from, we are talking about just 10 students of Ghana for the whole of the country where they have sat for these examinations. This is to encourage students to perform very well and the criteria will come. But selecting 10 out of it to award them so that other students would — we would get the best from them. This is a motivation for our students. So I think this is good. We are

selecting the best 10 to give them the award.

Mr Speaker, if you go to other institutions, depending on the performance, those days when people were travelling to other countries, depending on the performance of the record of your A-levels, you are awarded a special scholarship and it does not matter whether the person is —and then we can use the eligibility criteria for the rest of the Ghanaians. So selecting just 10 out of it —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Anyimadu-Antwi?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Once you are saying that the Minister in consultation with the Board may, by Legislative Instrument, provide for eligibility criteria for government scholarships, if the criteria will be that the best 10 students should be granted scholarship, let it be part of the regulation, setting out the eligibility criteria. Because we cannot discriminate in the law, picking some to provide for it and leaving others for eligibility criteria. So the eligibility criteria should be holistic, including the best students.

On the provision that the Chairman wants to abandon?

Yes?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I just wanted to add up. You know, in

Ghana, we do not have only the WAEC exams. We have almost 50,000 Ghanaians who are also sitting for the Commission for Technical Vocational Education Training (TVET) exams and they are not catered for here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So whether TVET or WAEC exam, let us leave it for the regulations. The regulation will spell out the eligibility criteria.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, while we are abandoning that one, I will recommend that we still keep subclause (j), but we can modify it because there is always a need for skill upgrade. So, I would like to modify (j) to read “ensure that scholarships awarded for skill upgrade” —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So let us place on record that the Chairman’s proposed amendments to clause 3, subclause (j), is abandoned.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Yes, Mr Speaker, it is abandoned.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So let me hear you.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: It is abandoned, but the (j) should be deleted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, there is a further proposal that the entire (j) should be deleted.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: And that is for the consideration of the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kyei Asamoah?

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I want to recommend that we keep (j) and not delete it because we have scaling, rescaling, and upscaling. And with this, we want to upscale either in-country or outside country. So we want to amend it to read

“ensure that scholarships awarded for skills upgrading programmes are pursued in institutions in-country or outside country”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, there is a provision that says that scholarship will only be awarded if the course of study is not being offered in Ghana. So whether skill upgrading or not, once the skill upgrading is being offered in Ghana, you will not be given a foreign scholarship. So with that, the rendition that you are proposing to (j) is otiose because whether (j) is there or not, the skill upgrading will have to be done in the country unless the course is not offered in the country. I believe that is the reason for which Chairman is proposing that the entire subclause (j) be deleted.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Then I will put the question on the deletion of subclause (j) in its entirety.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 3, subclause (j) ordered to be deleted from the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Proposed amendment — Mr Speaker, I beg to move clause 3, subclause (k) “after effective”, *insert*, “and efficient”, to read:

“ensure effective and efficient decentralisation of the operations of the Authority to the Districts and Regions of the country”.

I so move.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, “effective and efficient decentralisation”. What is the addition to effective decentralisation that efficiency is coming to add?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So if decentralisation is done, and in doing that particular decentralisation, they pick some regions and some districts, is that effective and efficient?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Let us admit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Should I put a question on the Chairman’s amendment?

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any further amendment to clause 3?

9.35 p.m.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, there is one amendment which has not been advertised. In consultation with the Chairman of the Public Administration and State Interests—

We are proposing that we add one new paragraph to read:

“prescribe the criteria for the grant of scholarship by Government institutions”.

Mr Speaker, we are saying so because it is in the memorandum accompanying the Bill, but not effectively captured in the Bill and once they are going to regulate the administration of a scholarship, we feel strongly that it should be part of the functions of the Authority.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you have given that particular function to the alter ego that is the Board in 5(b). So once the Board is an alter ego of the Authority and the Board is going to determine the criteria and the terms for the award of Government scholarship, why is the Authority again going to do

the same thing? What is the difference between the Authority and the Board in terms of physical action?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, we abandon the proposed amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon?

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, I want to add one other clause to paragraph—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 3? So, the amendment is accordingly abandoned.

Yes, Hon Asante-Boateng. Let us hear you.

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, as I initially put across, we realised that there is no mechanism for Scholarship Secretariat to collaborate with other scholarship awarding institutions and as a function of the Authority, I would like us to introduce (m). I read:

“create a common platform to coordinate and effectively report on all scholarship awarded in the country”.

Mr Speaker, I am saying that because when you go through the entire Bill, *vis-à-vis* the memorandum accompanying it, the only word that we use for scholarship secretariat in tandem with other awarding institutions is just collaboration. But if we state “collaboration” without putting in place any mechanism as to how the

collaboration is going to be done, we leave a gap in the law. So, I am proposing that—Initially the Minister explained that there is an existing platform, but that platform is not backed by any law. So, if that platform exists, this law or Bill should create something which will enable it to be operational. That is why I am proposing that we introduce another clause there as (m) to support that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Have you adverted your mind to clause 30 of the Bill?

Mr Asante-Boateng: Clause?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 30.

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, I have seen that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What did the clause 30 say?

Mr Asante-Boateng: “The Authority shall, in the performance of the functions under this Act, collaborate with other relevant bodies”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, does that answer your concern?

Mr Asante-Boateng: It does not answer it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It does not answer your concern?

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, “collaboration” does not bite. Collaboration is just collaboration. But it should have a mechanism based on

which that collaboration is to take place. That is all I am saying.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, your proposal is the mechanism?

Mr Asante-Boateng: Yes. To make it mandatory.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee? Then I will come to Hon Zanetor.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, the agreement between Chairman and me is that when we come to clause 30, we will take that proposed amendment not under functions of the Authority. That was the agreement we made. So, bringing it here at 3 is what I have a challenge with. So, if he can wait, when we get to 30, then he raises the issue then we look at it carefully.

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, I see that as a function that they are supposed to perform. That is why, upon second thought, I am proposing that we put that particular rendition under the function.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Asante-Boateng, I think we should listen to the Chairman of the Committee because clause 30 is saying that:

“The Authority shall in the performance of the functions under this Act, collaborate with other relevant bodies”.

So, when the Authority is going to perform their functions under this Act,

they need to perform that particular function in collaboration with the relevant agencies which for me includes all other bodies that award scholarship. So, this is a platform where if you have benefited from scholarship from Ghana Gas, in collaboration with Ghana Gas, they will be able to determine that you have already benefited scholarship from Ghana Gas. As a result, the government scholarship will not be granted to you to avoid double grant of scholarship.

But let me hear from Hon Zanetor.

Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings: Thank you, Mr Speaker. If I may, I believe what the Hon Member is pushing for is a verifiable database on which all persons awarded scholarships from the various governmental agencies can be harmonised. So, I am not proffering an amendment, but just suggesting that then the insertion of a database somewhere within the Bill, which would take care of that aspect of what he is trying to introduce, if I am not mistaken.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is why the Chairman of the Committee is proposing that when we come to clause 30, where they will be doing the collaboration, then we can introduce a clause that will cover availability of a database as a form of collaboration.

Yes?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, at the Consideration Stage, this issue that my Brother would want to advocate here came up. But, Mr Speaker, I think beyond collaboration, we cannot insert

any clause, because different legislations have created these different establishments. So, to put it in this law, they would not have any influence on the others, apart from their meeting to collaborate. So, the best is to get a database so that one would not get a double benefit.

Mr Speaker, unless the Government takes a decision that by way of policy, we would want to fuse all these establishments together, I do not think we can use one law to have an influence on the others because GETFund has a different law, Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) has a different creation and now we are looking at the Scholarship Secretariat. But I believe with time, there may be consolidation of all these and until we get there, we should be comfortable with collaboration.

9.45p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Ghana Statistical Service is working on something like that, but we are not there yet. So, at this level, we can leave it as collaboration, so that if part of the collaboration is to put together their database to be in respect of scholarship, to be able to determine beneficiaries at each stage, then the proper word that we should use here is collaboration.

This is because it is the Ghana Scholarships Authority that will need evidence from them regarding the names and number of people they have already granted scholarships to, so that they will not also grant scholarship to those people

to avoid one person from benefitting from scholarships from several sources. It is through collaborative efforts that they will be able to achieve this particular aim.

Should I put the Question on—Yes, Hon Sosu?

Mr Francis-Xavier Sosu: Mr Speaker, if I get a sense of the discussion going on, there is the desire that this law can harmonise our scholarship regime in Ghana. We know there are different types of scholarships, for example, the GETFund Scholarship and the COCOBOD Scholarship Scheme. But then, it is possible that through this vehicle, if we are giving out COCOBOD Scholarships or GETFund Scholarships, applicants can go through the Authority. That way, the Authority can then create a common platform.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: By law, GETFund is also established to grant scholarships and that is the law that relates to GETFund. How are we now going to say that the law that establishes GETFund, with modalities to give out scholarships, should now be harmonised by this law?

Mr Sosu: Mr Speaker, this is an Authority given the sole obligation to administer—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, it is not the sole obligation to grant scholarships.

Mr Sosu: Very well. Mr Speaker, I will abandon my—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Other institutions, as a result of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), can also grant scholarships.

Mr Sosu: Mr Speaker, would it not be the best approach? Once you are a government institution, as part of your CSR, if you want to grant scholarship, we know there is an Authority. So, if that government institution has an annual budget for scholarship, we know that they administer that annual budget through the Authority. That way, the Authority would have that common platform that we are talking about here.

Mr Speaker, I believe that this is a possibility, but, perhaps, that is not what the object or the intended purpose of the promoters of the Bill is, so I will abandon it so that you can put the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Asante-Boateng: Mr Speaker, my problem is that when we refer to paragraph four of the accompanying Memorandum, with your indulgence, I will read:

“Furthermore, the multiplicity of public institutions handling or awarding scholarships without collaboration with the Secretariat is another challenge that affects the effectiveness and efficiency of the Secretariat in the performance of its functions. This, in particular, affects the responsibility of the Secretariat to report fully and accurately to Government and other stakeholders on

all scholarships awarded by public institutions in the country.”

When we look at this, that is an object contained in the Memorandum to solve this problem. So, if there is no mechanism to tidy up the various institutions, such that there will be a common platform that this Bill is creating, then the Memorandum seems to be somehow misleading.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Asante-Boateng, if you look at the Memorandum that you referred to, it even says:

“...the multiplicity of public institutions handling or awarding scholarships without collaboration...”

That is why clause 30 used the words “in collaboration with other relevant institutions”, so if they collaborate with other relevant institutions, the issue of multiplicity of award of scholarship would be avoided because the Scholarships Authority is going to collaborate with GETFund, Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and all relevant institutions that grant scholarships. The essence is to be able to know those who have already benefited from them, so that they do not grant scholarships to those people to avoid multiplicity of scholarships.

Yes, I am taking the last comment.

Mr Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, coming from where my Colleague just mentioned, I think we can have the Interpretation column to interpret

“collaboration” as “including harmonisation of database”. I say this because, Mr Speaker, we have people moving from one institution to another receiving scholarships and we do not have any database on them. They move from GETFund to GNPC to other institutions, just taking scholarships from all these places.

This Bill, Mr Speaker, does not give any indication that this Authority will have a database on them and that is exactly what my Colleague said. If we do not want to introduce any clause, let us have it under the Interpretation clause where “collaboration” will be interpreted.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I think this problem is very simple. A few minutes ago, we indicated that people who apply to the Authority for scholarships will be published and the publication will be by a procedure set out in the Regulation, whether it is going to be on the website or in a newspaper of national circulation. So, the other relevant institutions will also be in a position to determine that an individual has already applied to the Ghana Scholarships Authority.

So, the Ghana Scholarships Authority, before granting the scholarship, may want to find out from other relevant institutions the people they have granted scholarships to in a collaborative effort, so that they also do not grant

scholarships to similar people and that is what clause 30 talks about.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 3 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, it is almost 10.00 p.m., we are in your hands since we have sat for over five hours. My application will be that we adjourn the House today. Members have done well today and they are very tired.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, once again, let me use the opportunity to congratulate Members for their endurance. It is almost 10.00 p.m., but we are here taking the Consideration Stage of the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025. You are highly commended.

Yes, that brings us to the end of the Consideration Stage for today.

Hon Members, we have done more than five hours; guided by Order 56(2), I will proceed to adjourn the House. The House is accordingly adjourned till Thursday, 17th July, 2025 at two o'clock in the forenoon.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 9.54 p.m. till Thursday, 17th July, 2025, at 2.00 p.m.

